

INTRODUCTION TO GAMES

Game Ideation 01



GAME IDEAS...





GENRES

JUMP AND RUN

ROGUE LITE

RPG

SHOOTER

OPEN WORLD GAME



THINK OUT OF THE BOX



THANK GOODNESS YOU ARE HERE





CONSUME ME





DESPELOTE







The LUCKY SQUIRE



JUN FUJIKI



<http://jun-fujiki.com/>

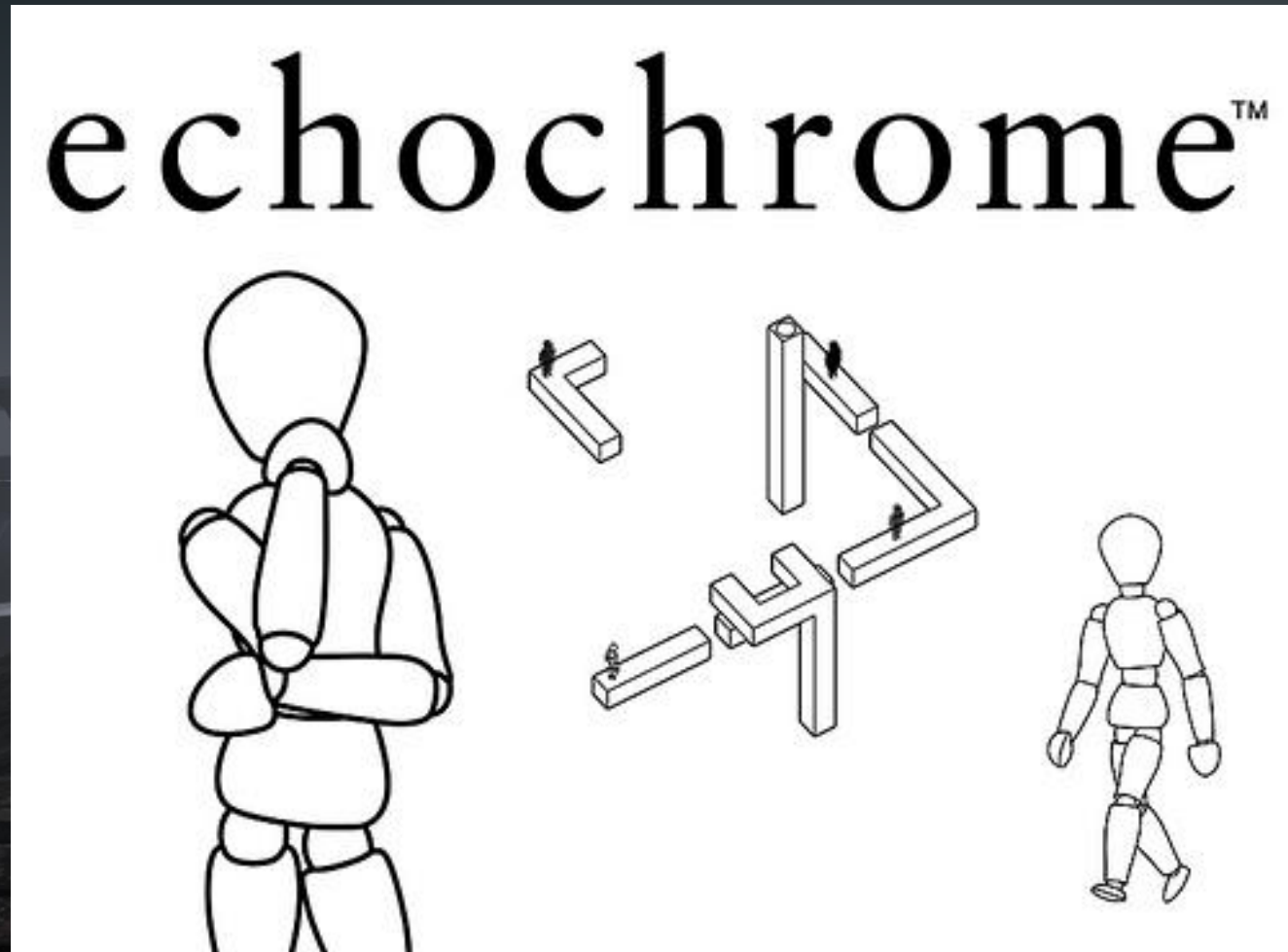
JUN FUJIKI: GAME BORDER



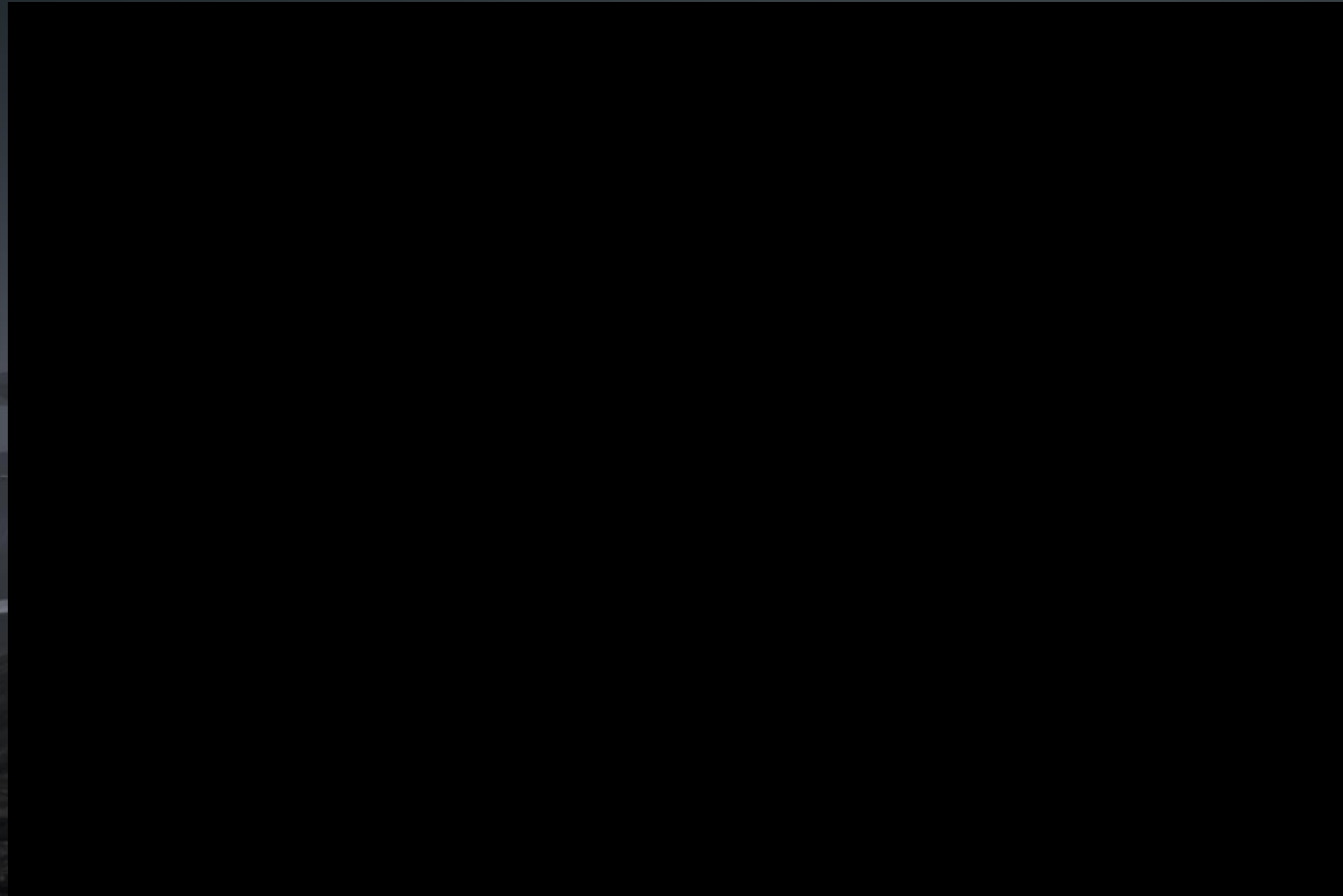
JUN FUJIKI: GAME BORDER



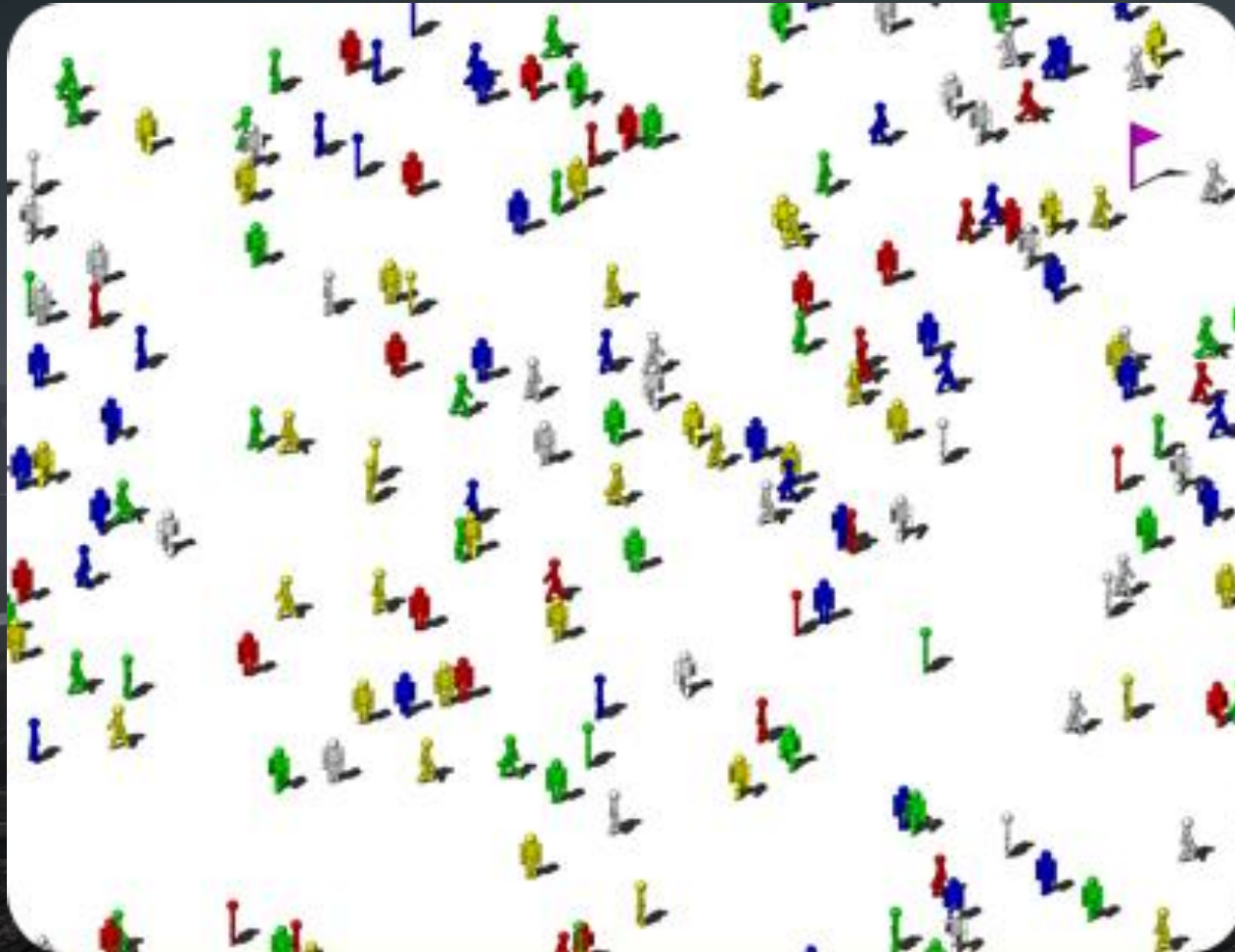
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GAME IDEAS YOU LIKE?



IDEA TO GAME

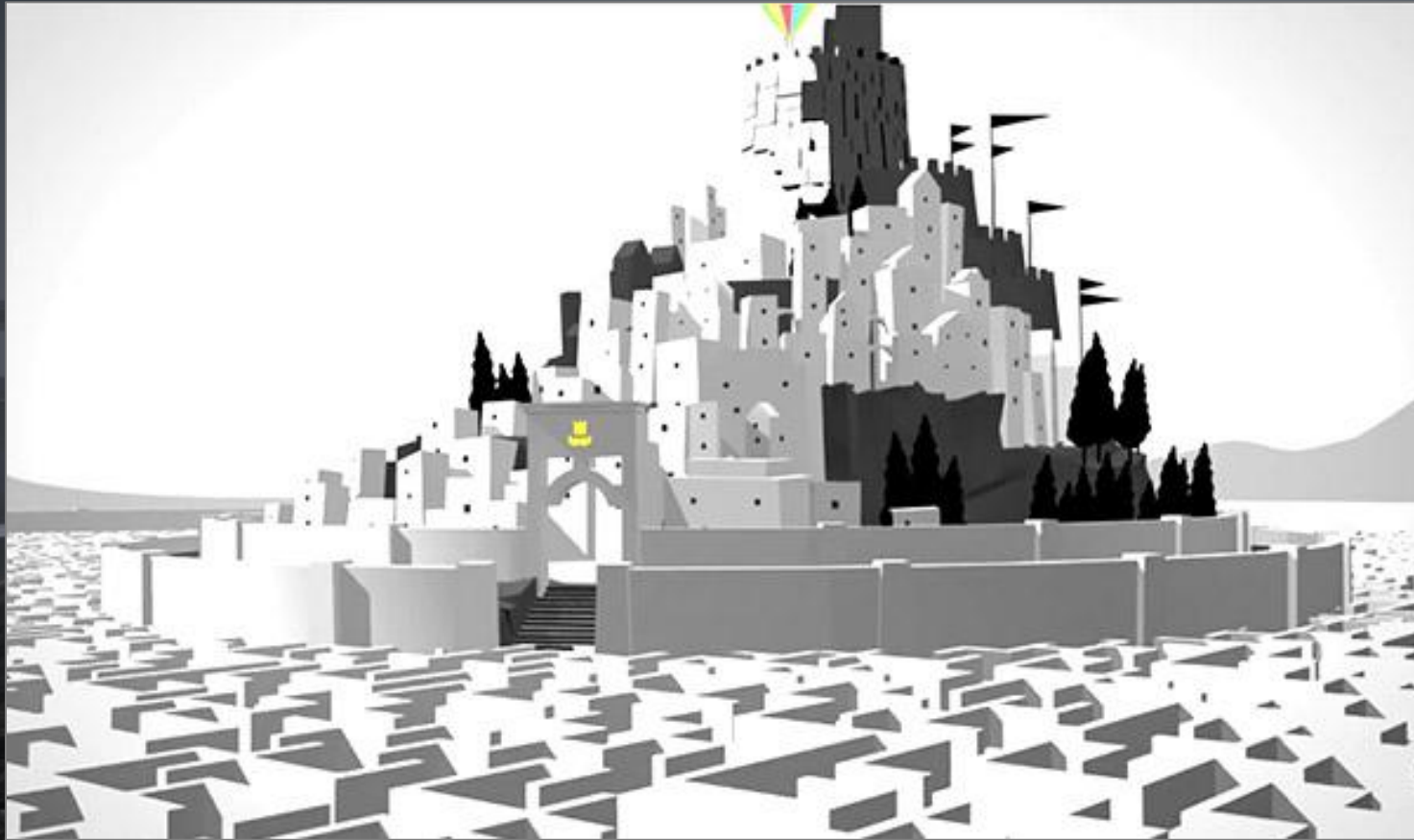


GAMES

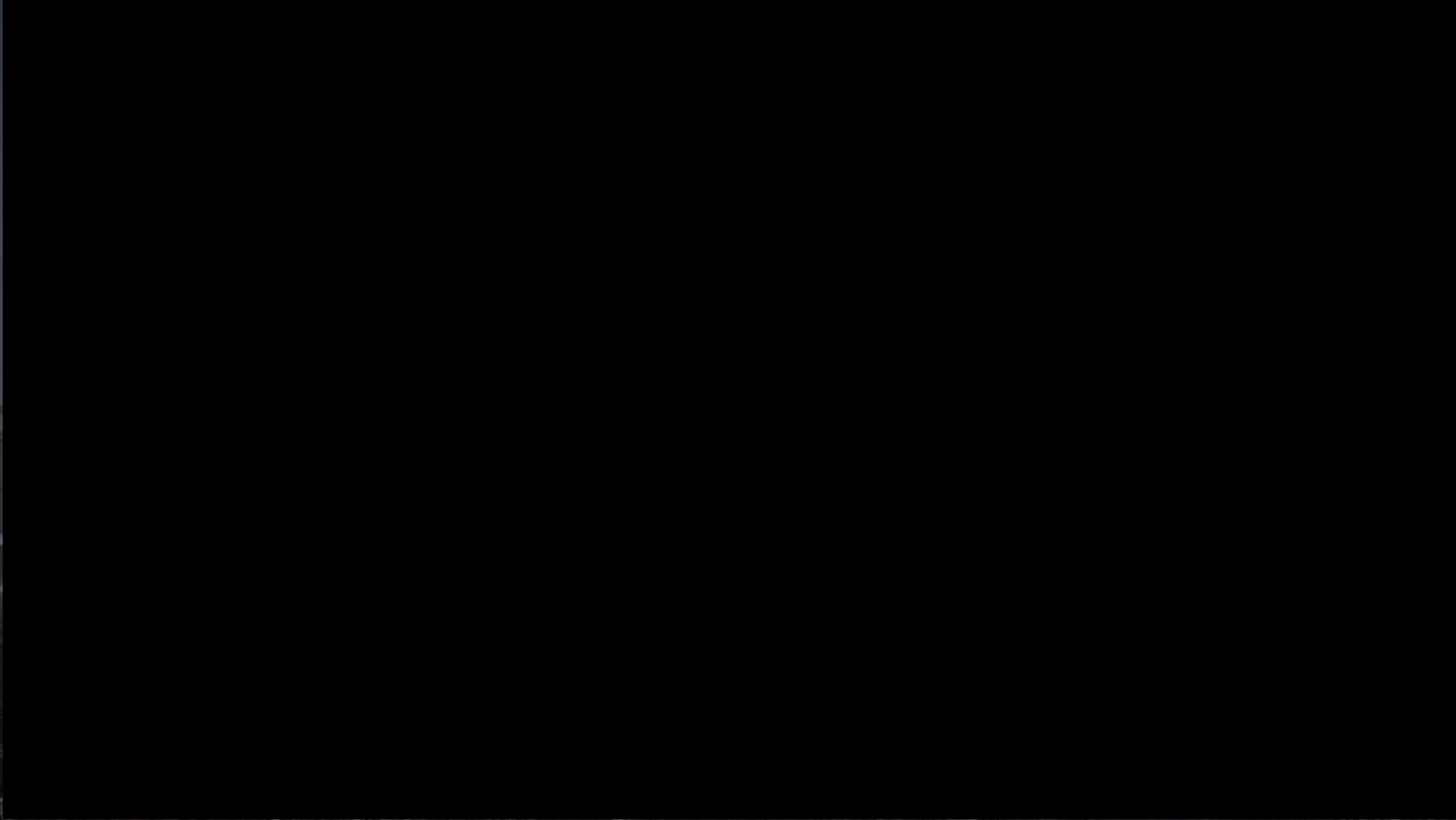
- The Unfinished Swan
- Braid
- Monument Valley



THE UNFINISHED SWAN



THE UNFINISHED SWAN







THE UNFINISHED SWAN: HARD FACTS

- Developer: Giant Sparrow
- Development: 2008 - 2012
- Publisher: Sony (SCEA)
- Director: Ian Dallas
- Team size: 12

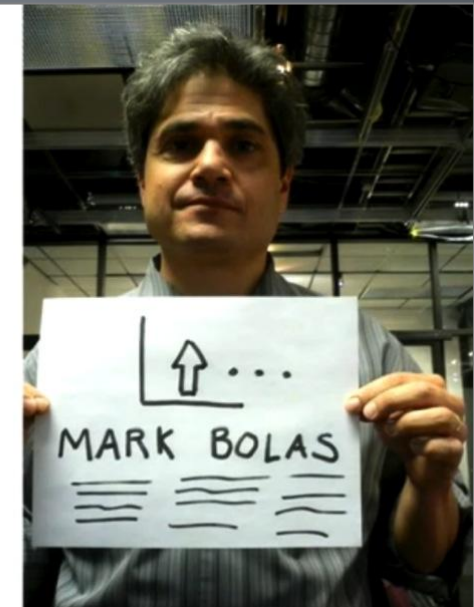


THE UNFINISHED SWAN: PROCESS

Development of game idea?

- Started as a student project
- Lots of different prototypes
- One game prototype: paint a white room

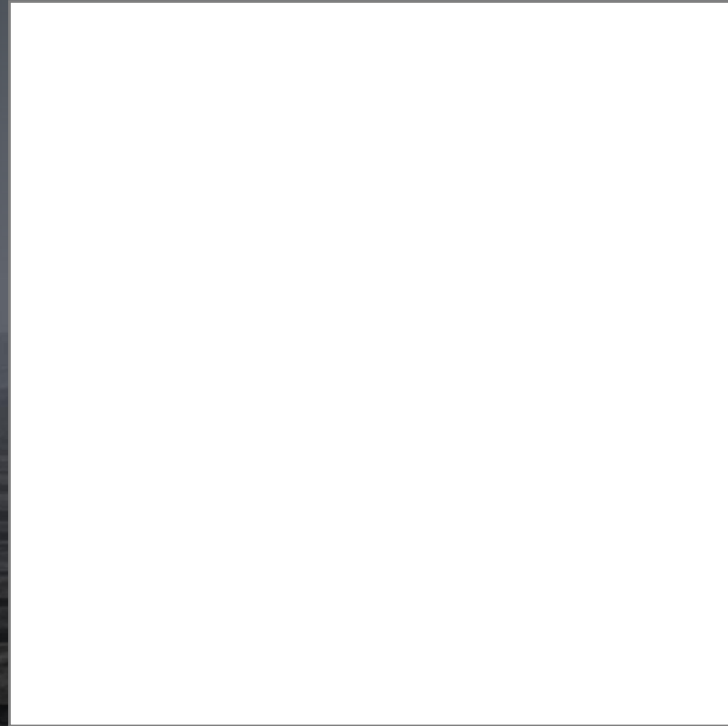
Every week I made
a new prototype
for this man.



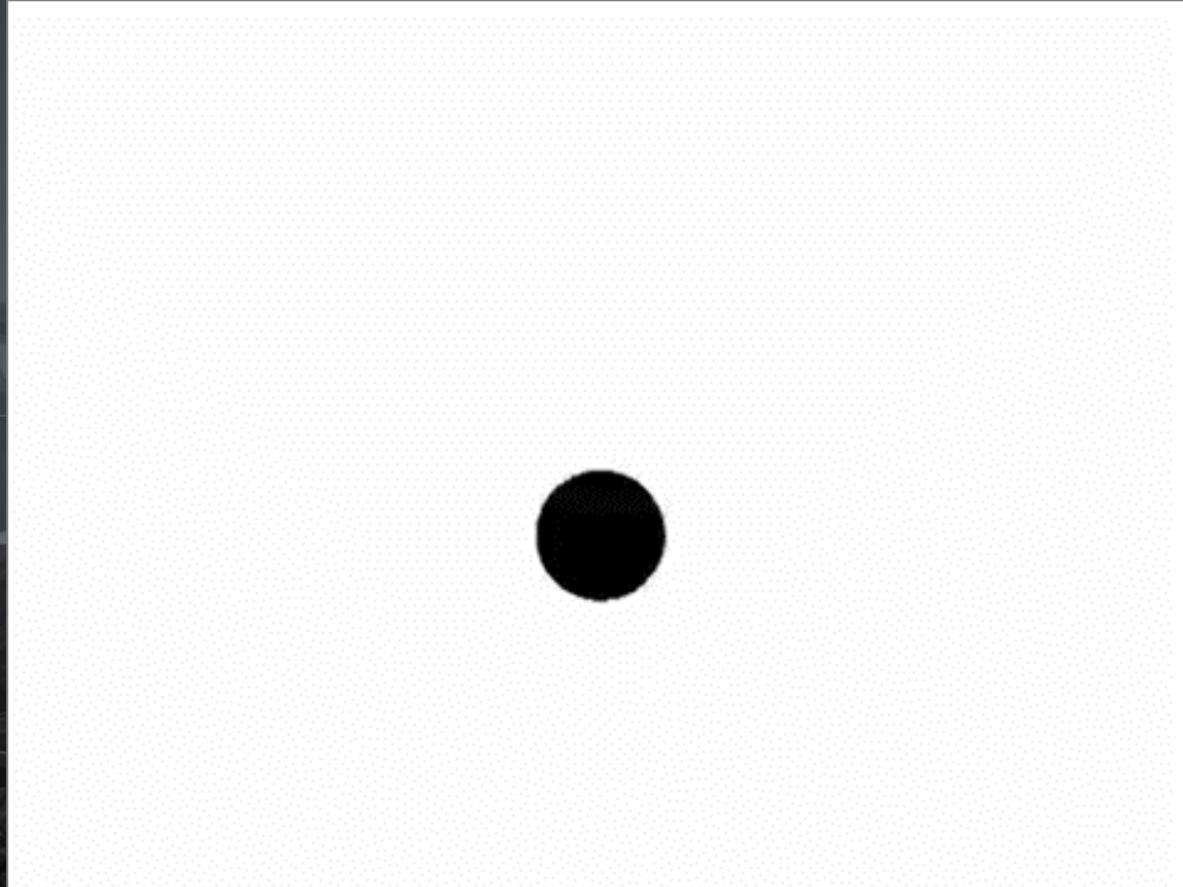
THE UNFINISHED SWAN: PROCESS

Game design interesting?

- Theme: curiosity
- Blank white paper



THE UNFINISHED SWAN: PROCESS



THE UNFINISHED SWAN: PROCESS

Biggest challenges?

- Guiding the player through the game
- Sandbox...
- VS scripted scenarios



THE UNFINISHED SWAN: PROCESS

Prototype without goals

- Idea is interesting...
- ... for 5 minutes
- Players lose track
- Solution: goals plus free exploration



THE UNFINISHED SWAN: GOALS

- **Clear long-term goal:** "find the swan"
- **Pretty clear mid-term goal:** "maybe I should checkout those swan footprints in the middle of the pond"
- **Very undefined short-term goal:** "how do I get to the middle of the pond?"

THE UNFINISHED SWAN: PROCESS

Keep players engaged?

- Goal: every 60 seconds something new to explore
- Example: small things (creatures) to new mechanic
- Design goal: explore not to master



THE UNFINISHED SWAN: PROCESS



<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ICayDVOsYIU>

THE UNFINISHED SWAN: PROCESS



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THE UNFINISHED SWAN: PROCESS

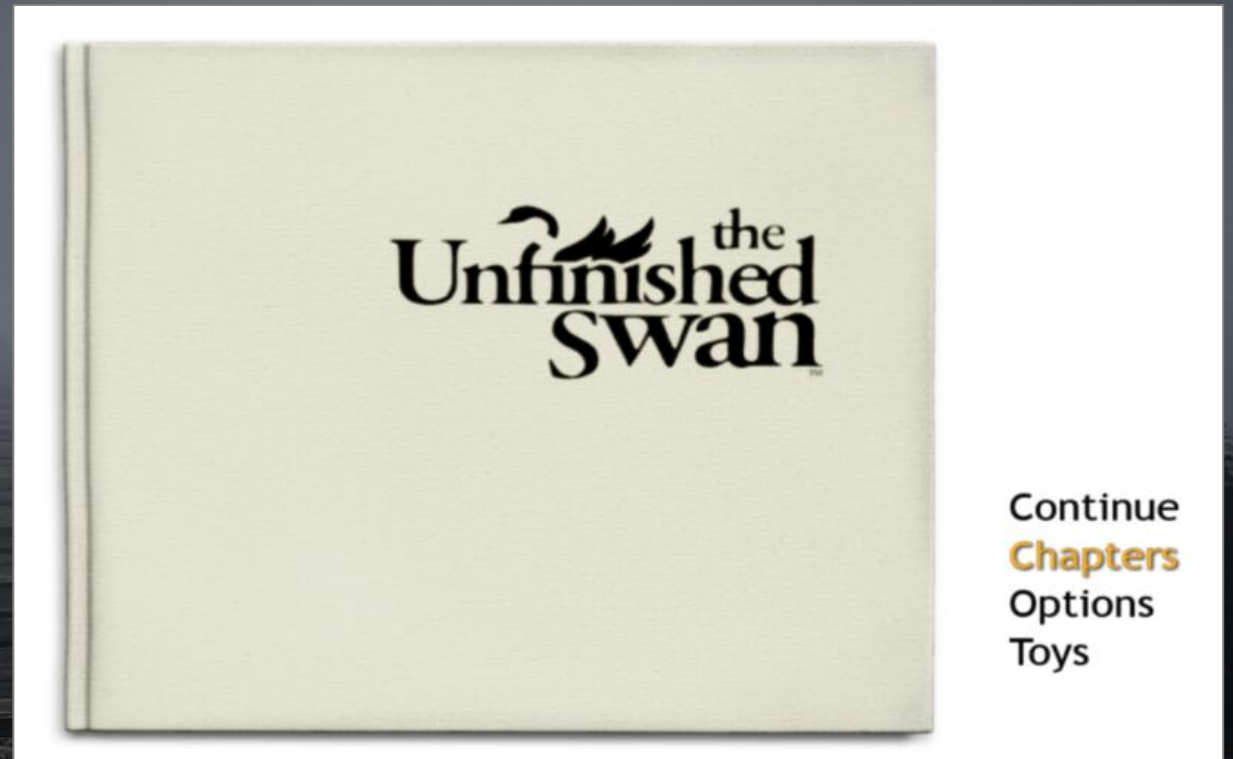


<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ICayDVOsYIU>

THE UNFINISHED SWAN: PROCESS

Inspiration: Story?

- Stories for children
- Dreaming
- See the world through the eyes of a child



THE UNFINISHED SWAN: PROCESS

Inspiration: Story?

- Alice in Wonderland
- Child explores kingdom...
- ... to find an animal



BRAID



BRAID: HARD FACTS

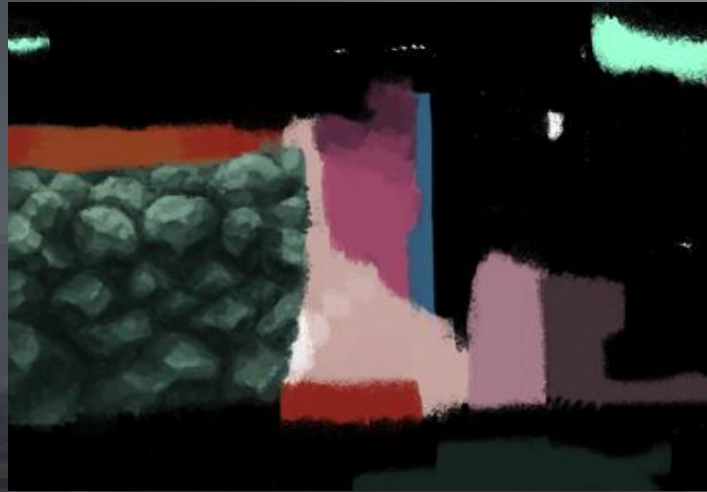
- Developer: Number One
- Release: 2008
- Publisher: Valve (Steam)
- Director: Jonathan Blow



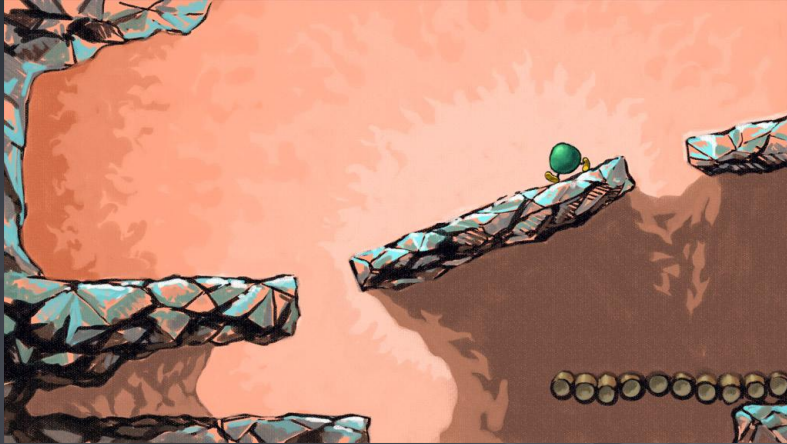
BRAID: PROTOTYPE...



BRAID: ART PROCESS



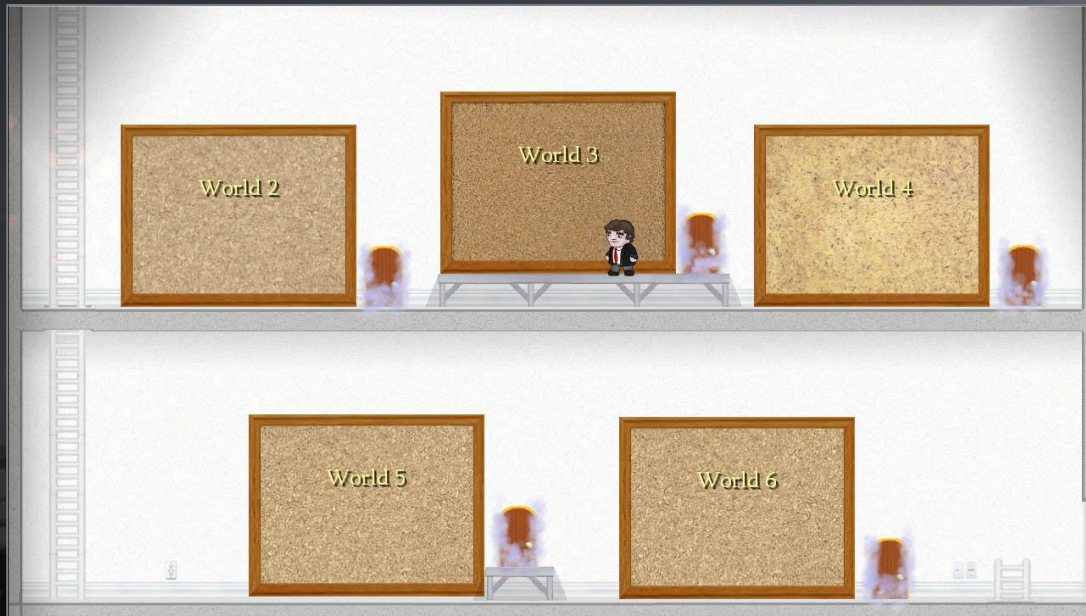
BRAID: ART PROCESS



BRAID: ART PROCESS



BRAID: ART PROCESS



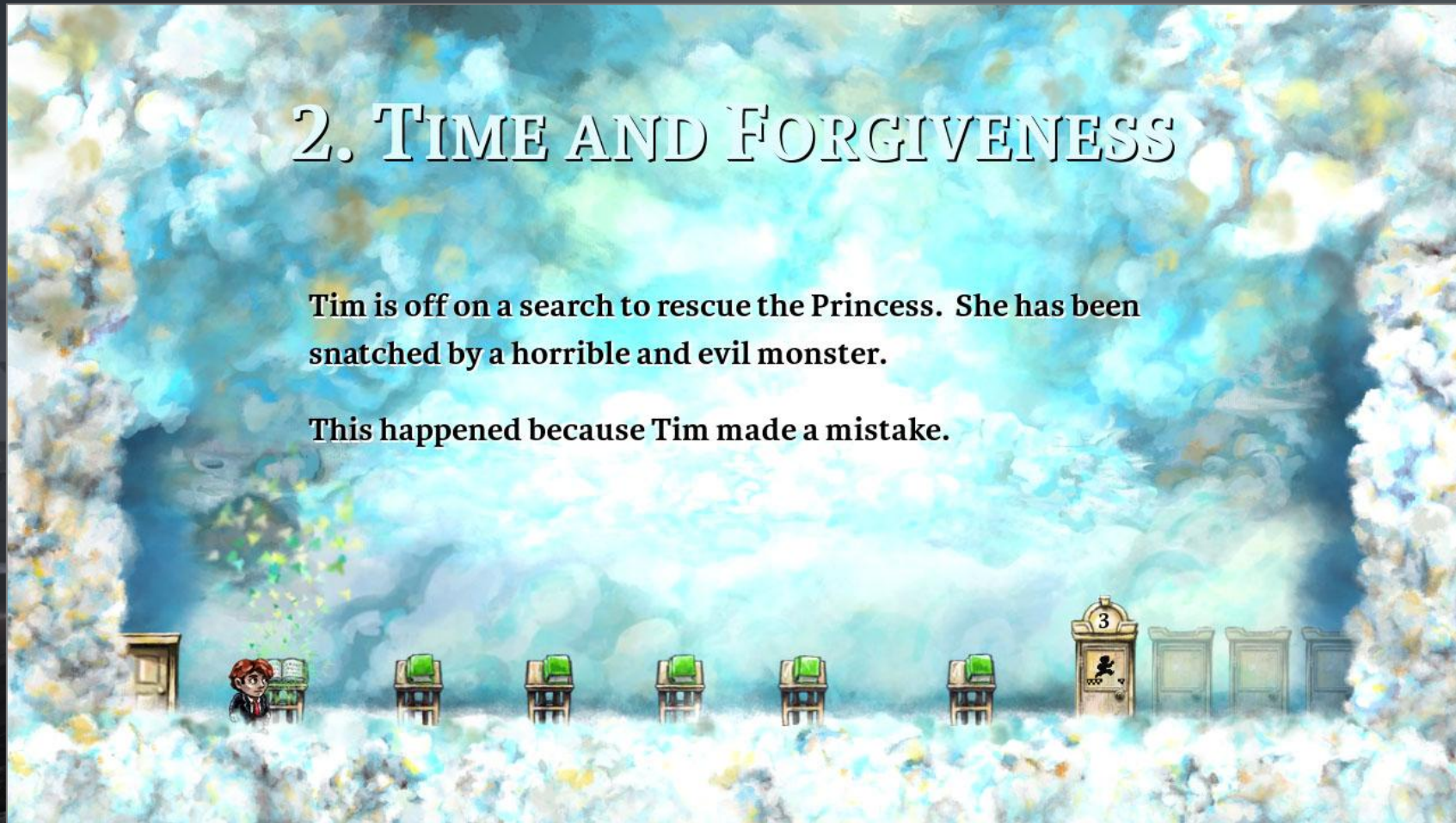
BRAID: ART PROCESS



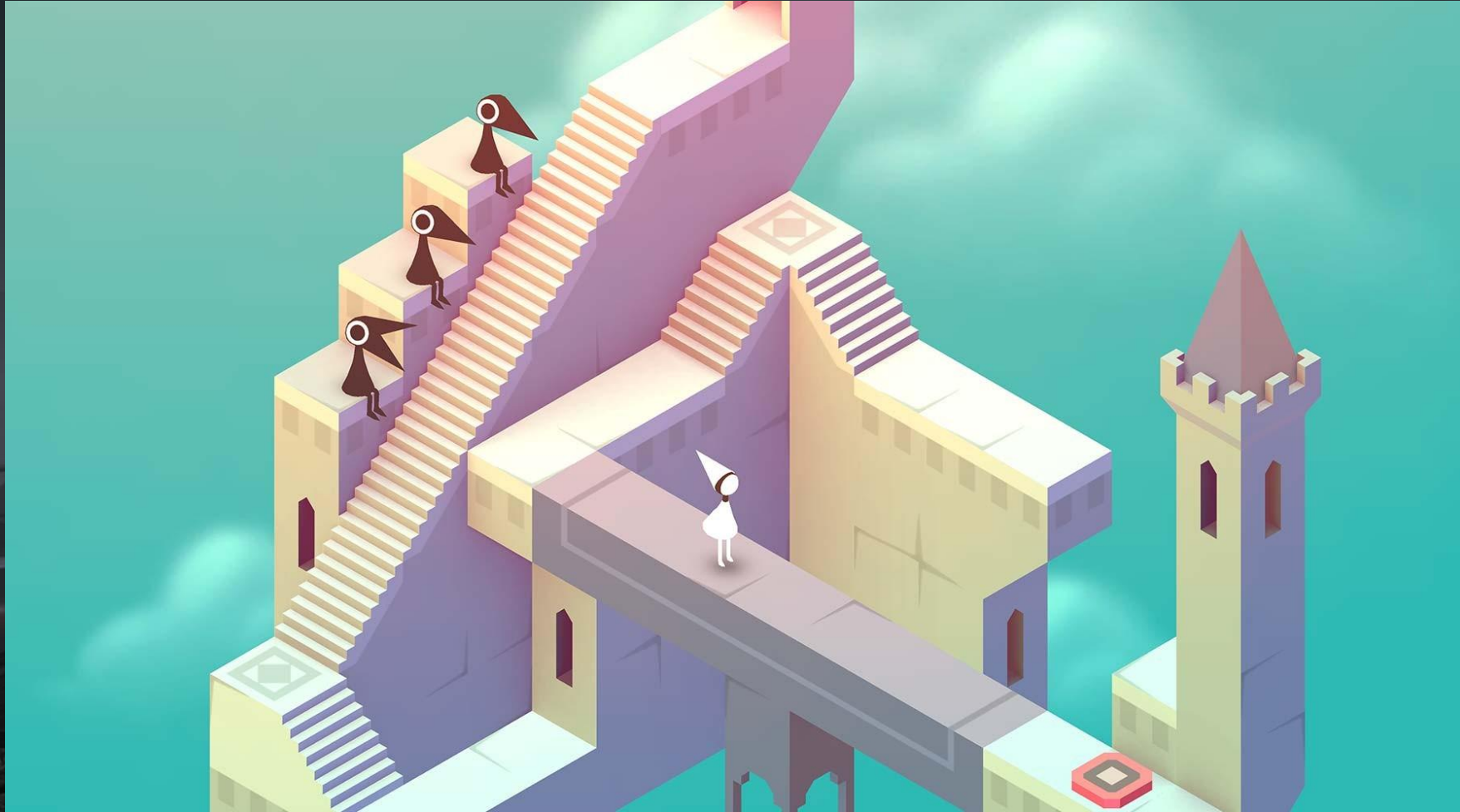
BRAID: ART PROCESS



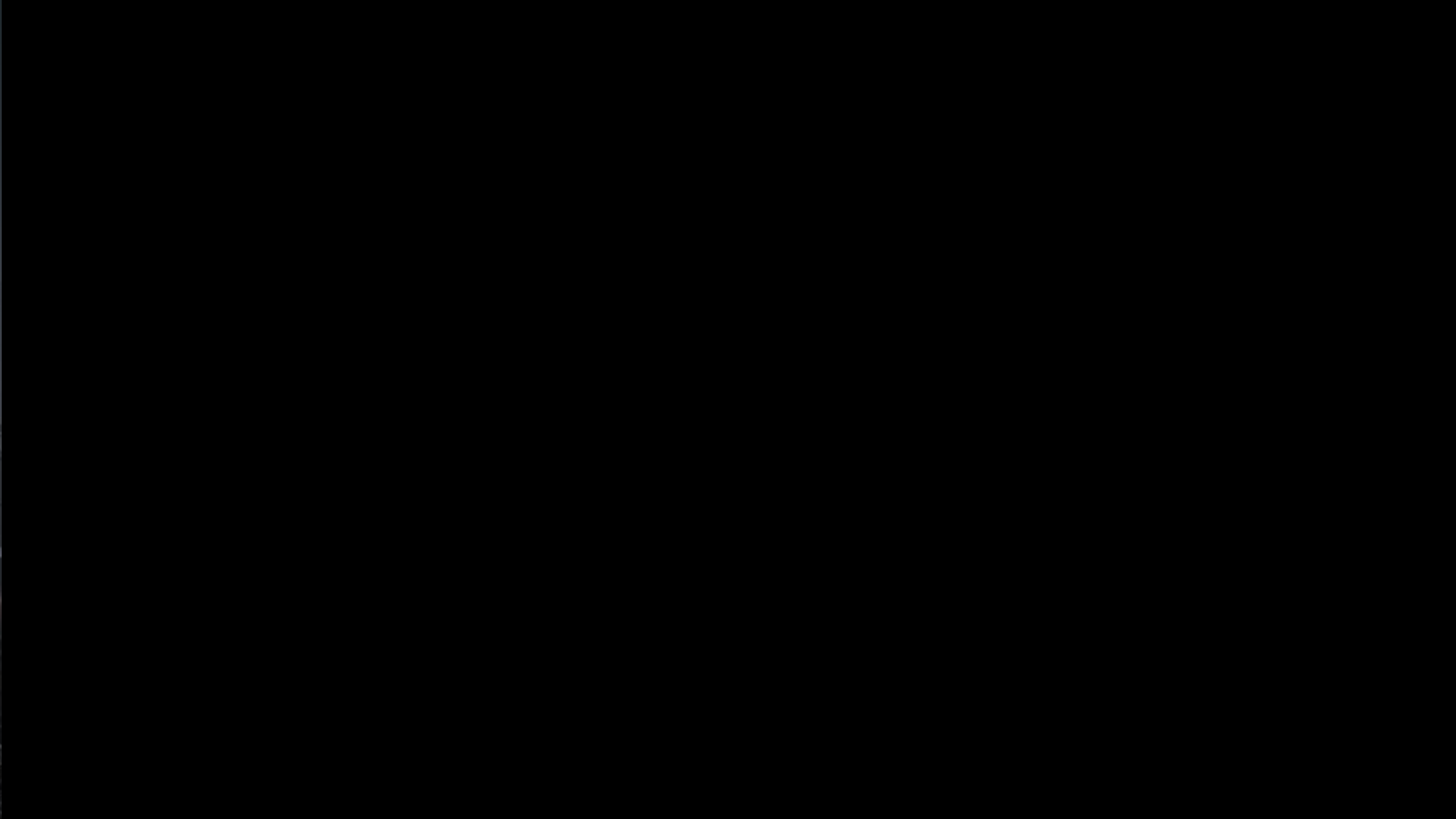
BRAID: ART PROCESS



MONUMENT VALLEY



MONUMENT VALLEY



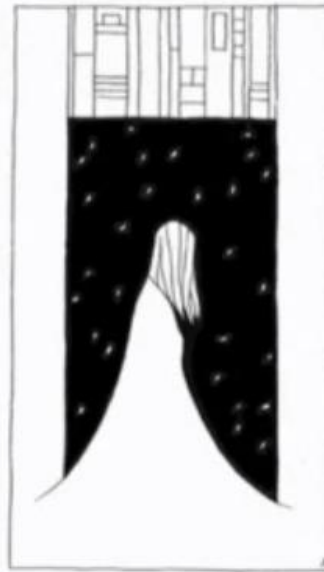
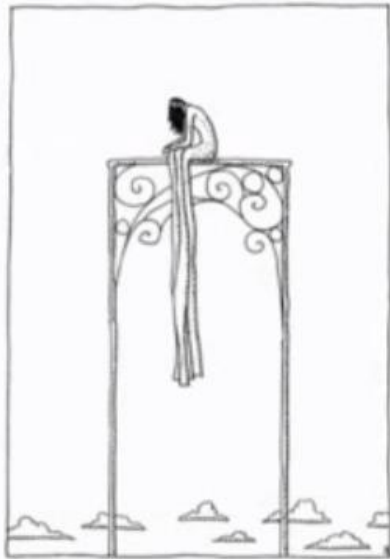
MONUMENT VALLEY

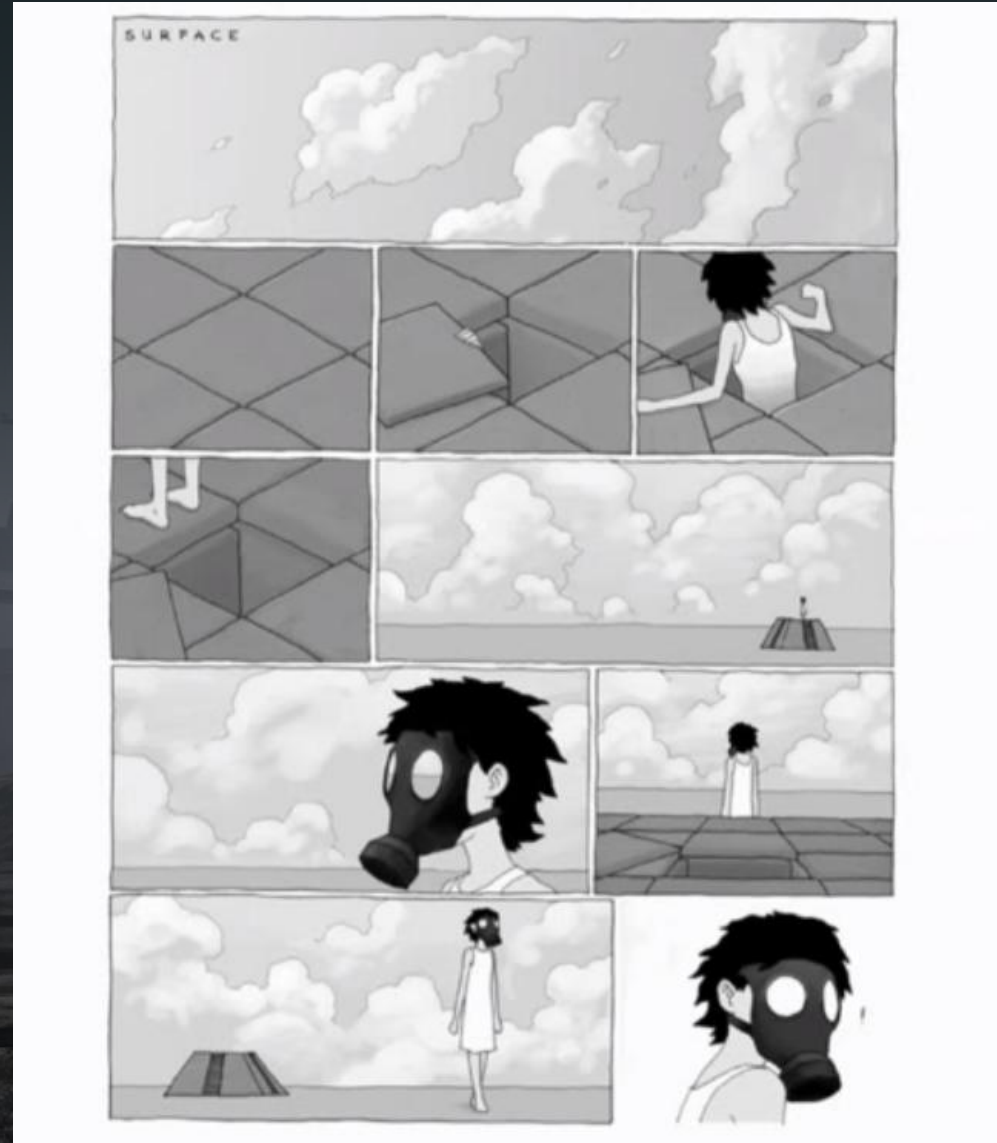
- We create entire **player experiences** — not just mechanics dressed up with art and story.
- For some players, **enjoyment** comes more from story, **art**, sound, less from gameplay.

MONUMENT VALLEY

Designing with **aesthetics** as a **focus**
leads to the creation of **different experiences**.

MY ILLUSTRATION WORK





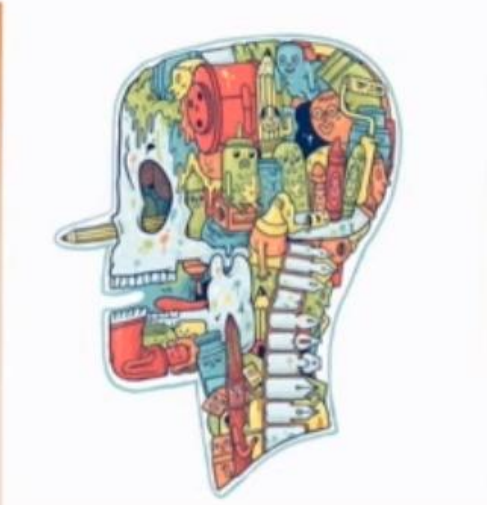


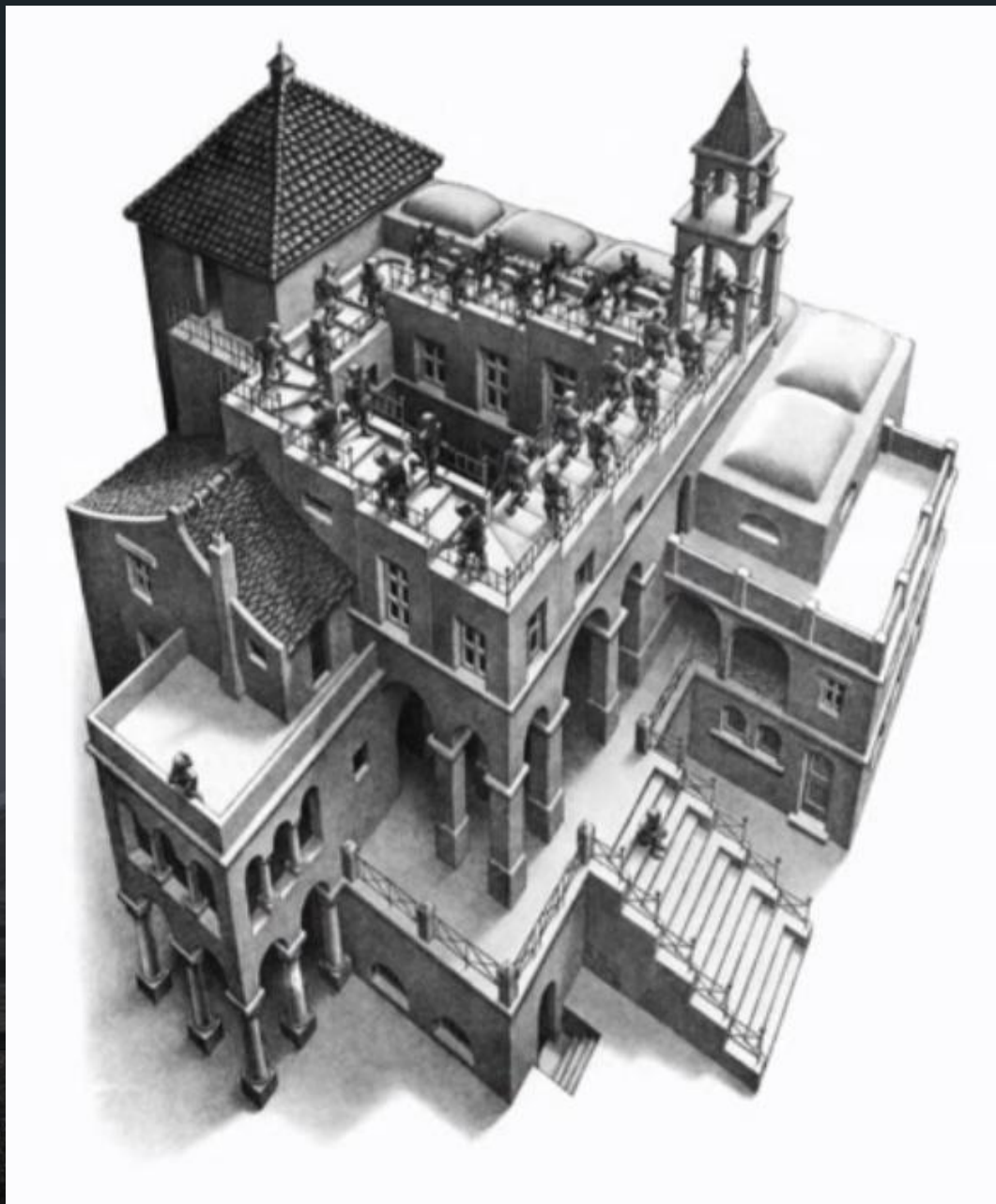


A LOVE OF ARCHITECTURE



LITTLE WORLDS

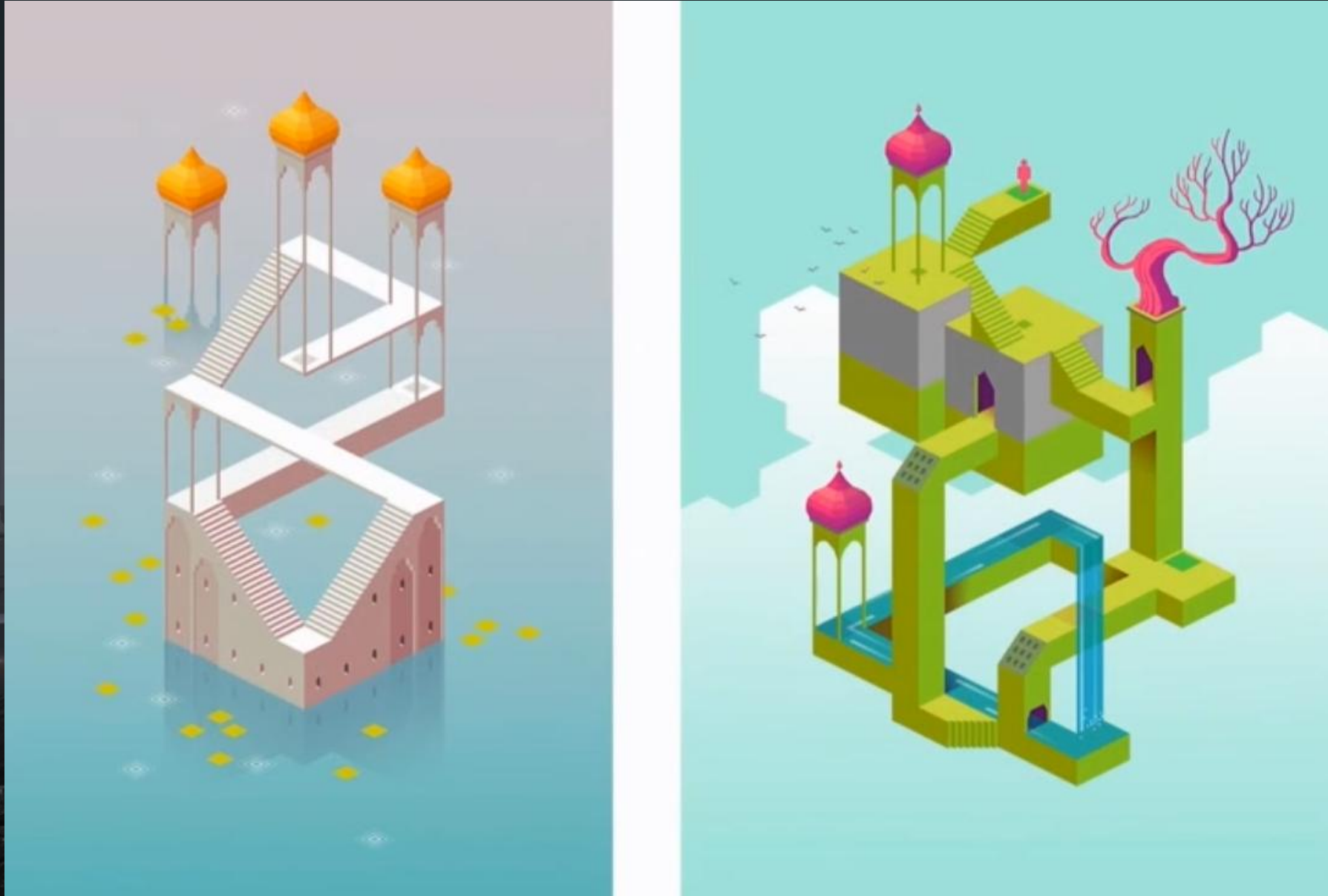






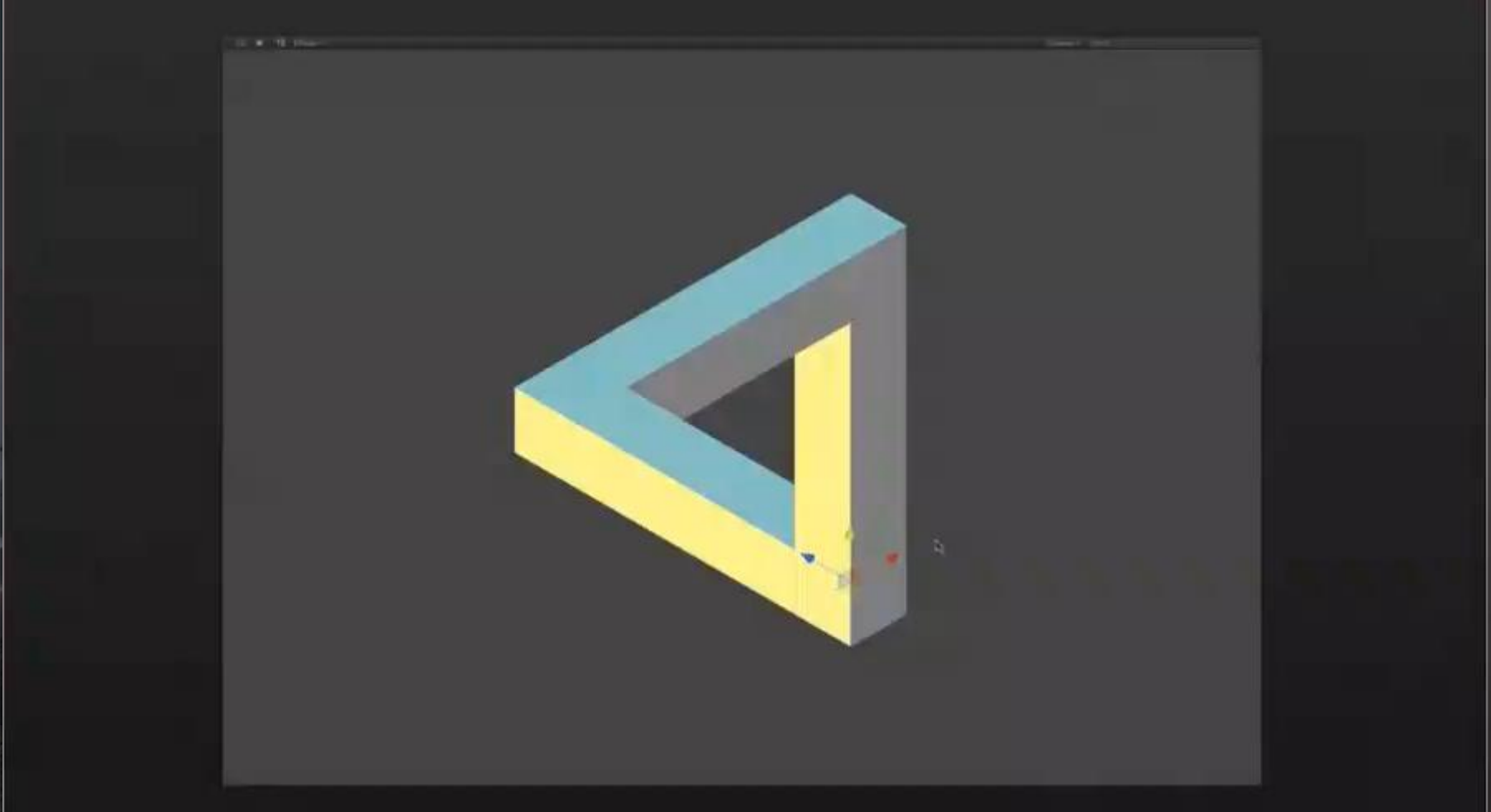


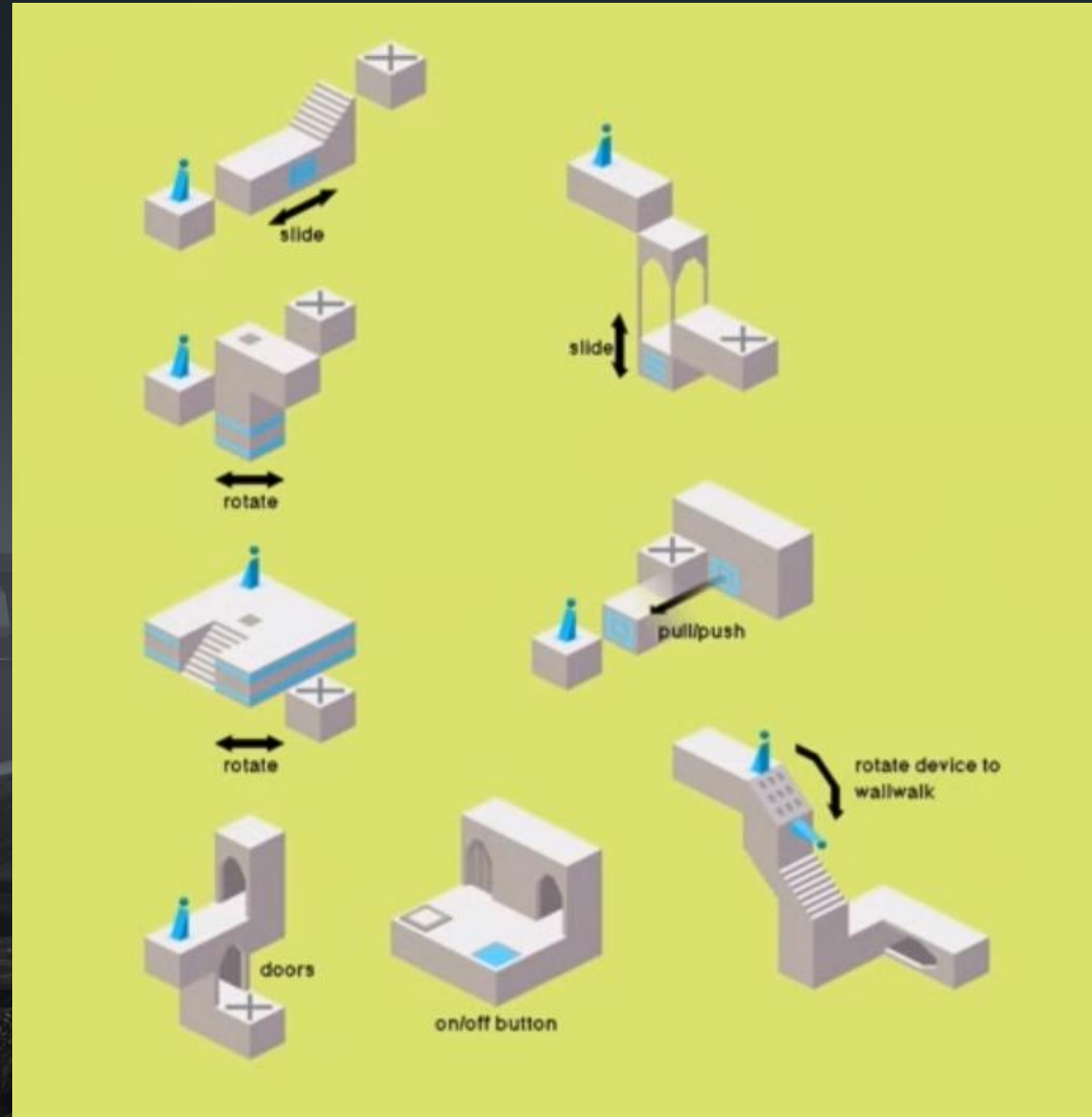
FIRST CONCEPT ART



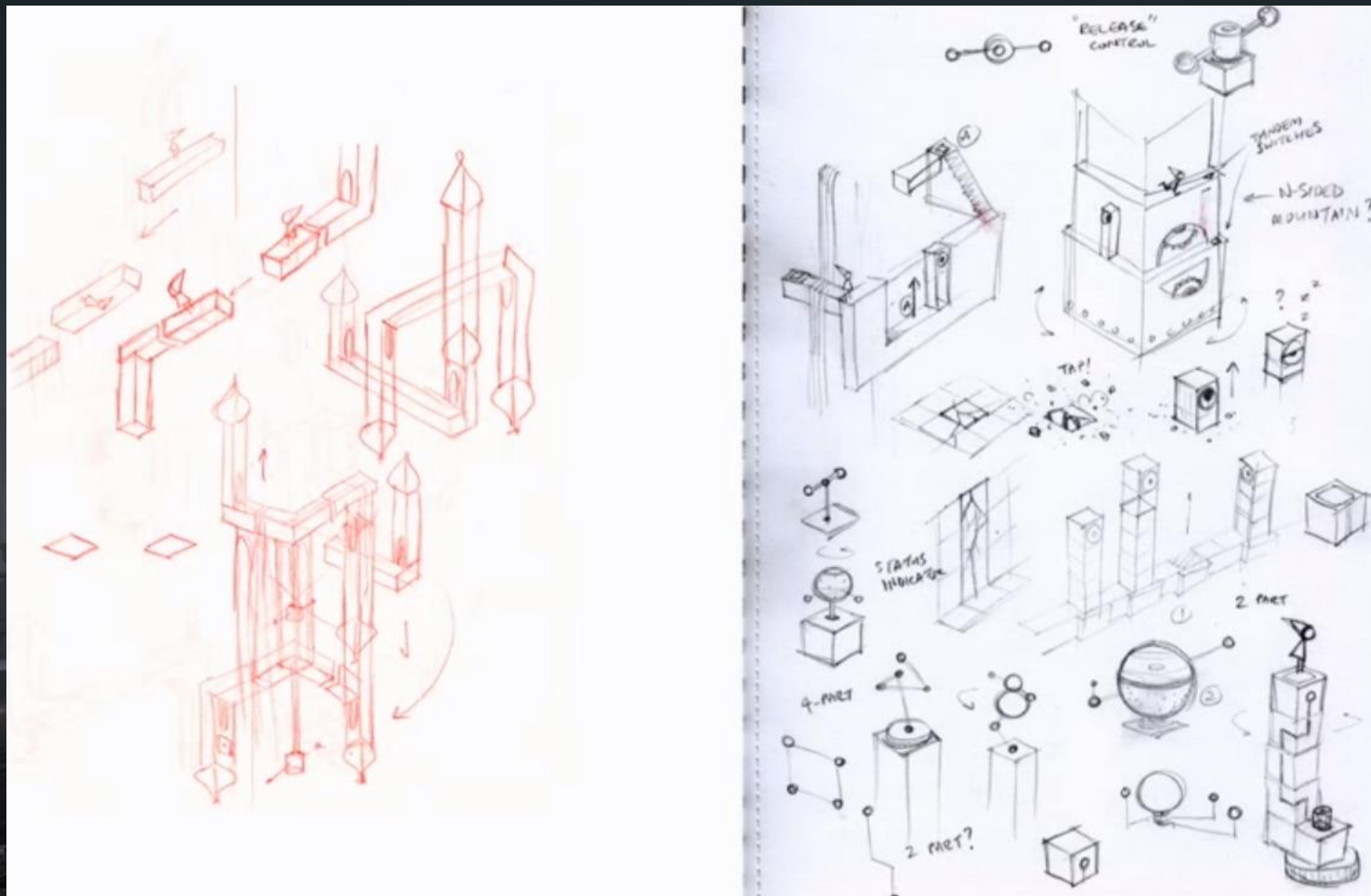


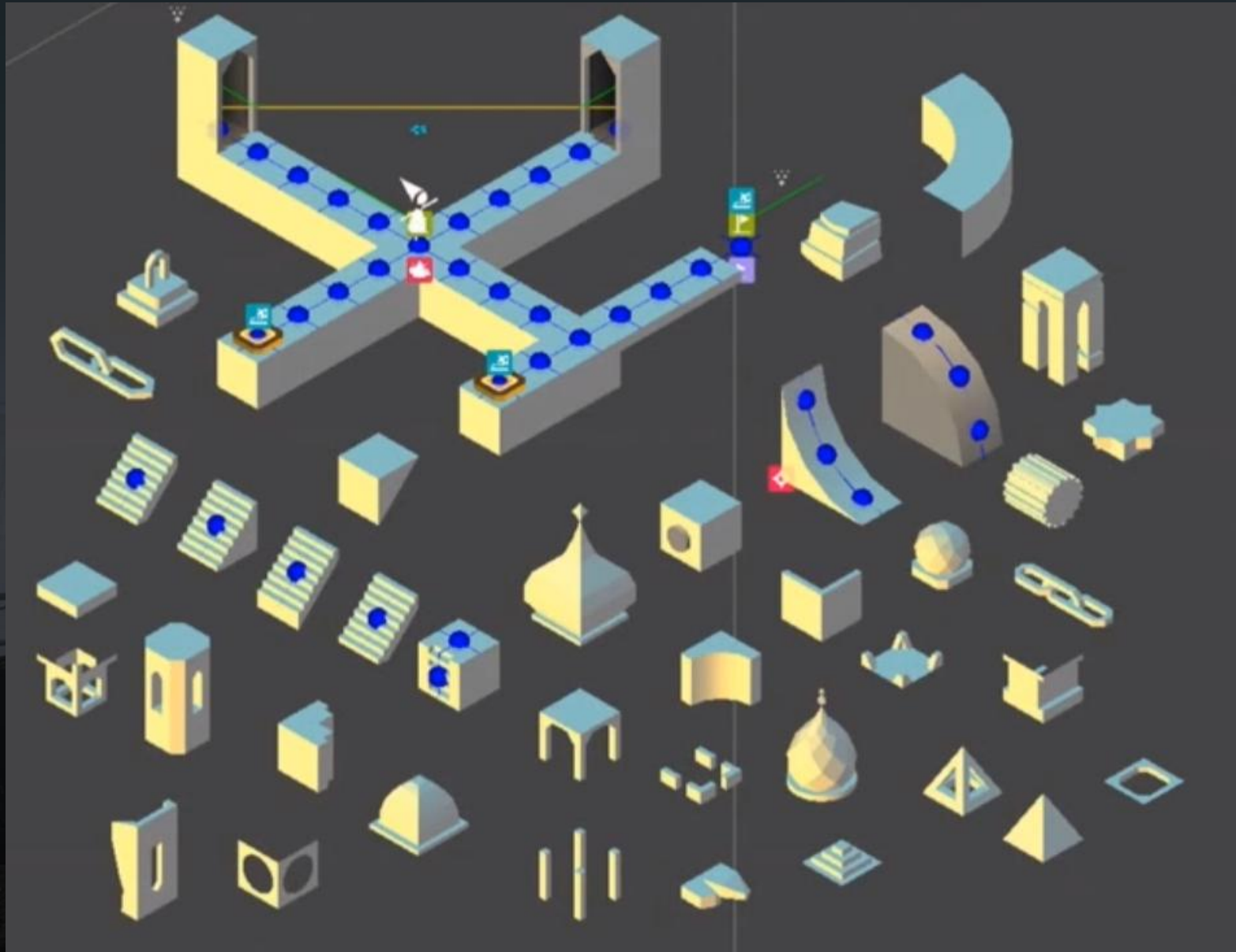
MONUMENT VALLEY



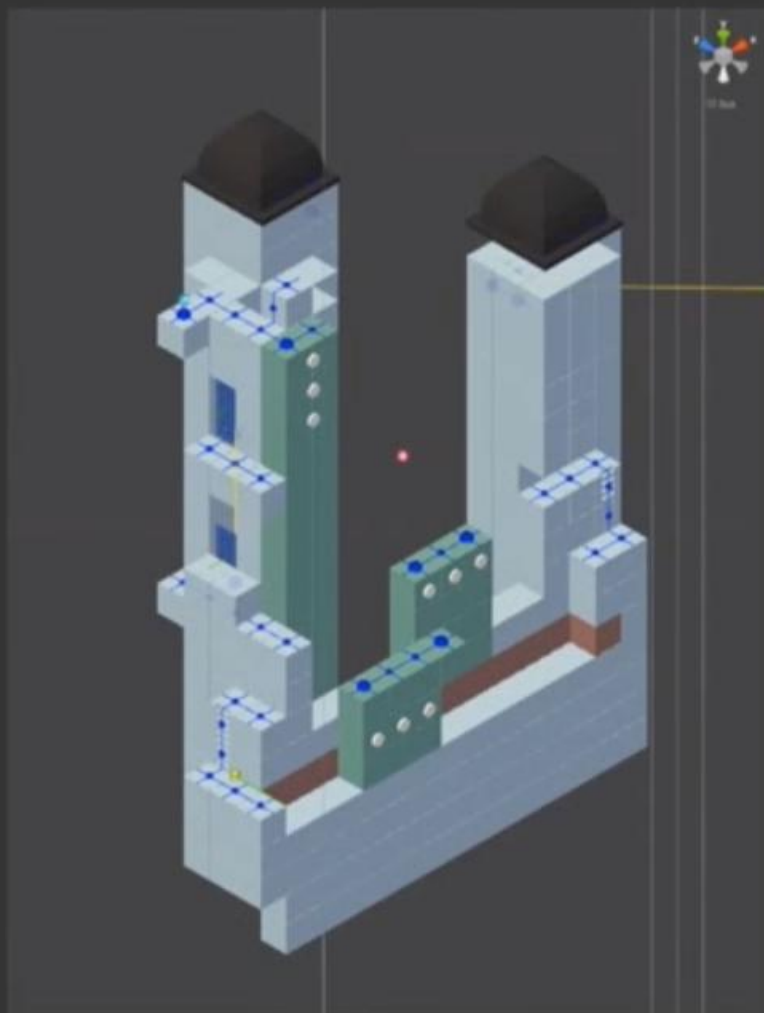








WHITEBOX
PIECES
(PARTIAL)



WHITE BOX

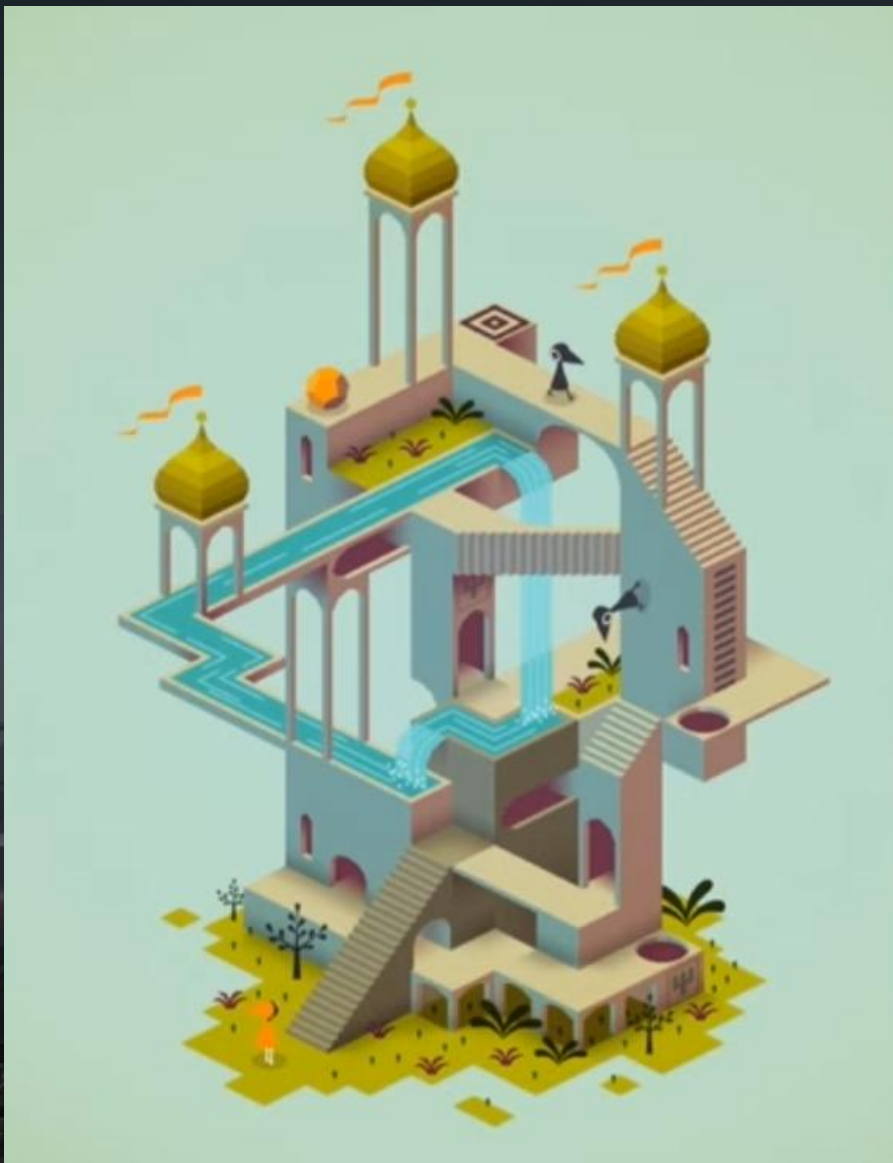


FINAL 'VIS'

MONUMENT VALLEY

WHITEBOX





IDEA TO STORY



4-LAYERS-NARRATIVE-DESIGN-APPROACH

- Thomas Grip (Frictional Games: SOMA)
- <https://frictionalgames.blogspot.com/2014/04/4-layers-narrative-design-approach.html>







NARRATIVE BASICS

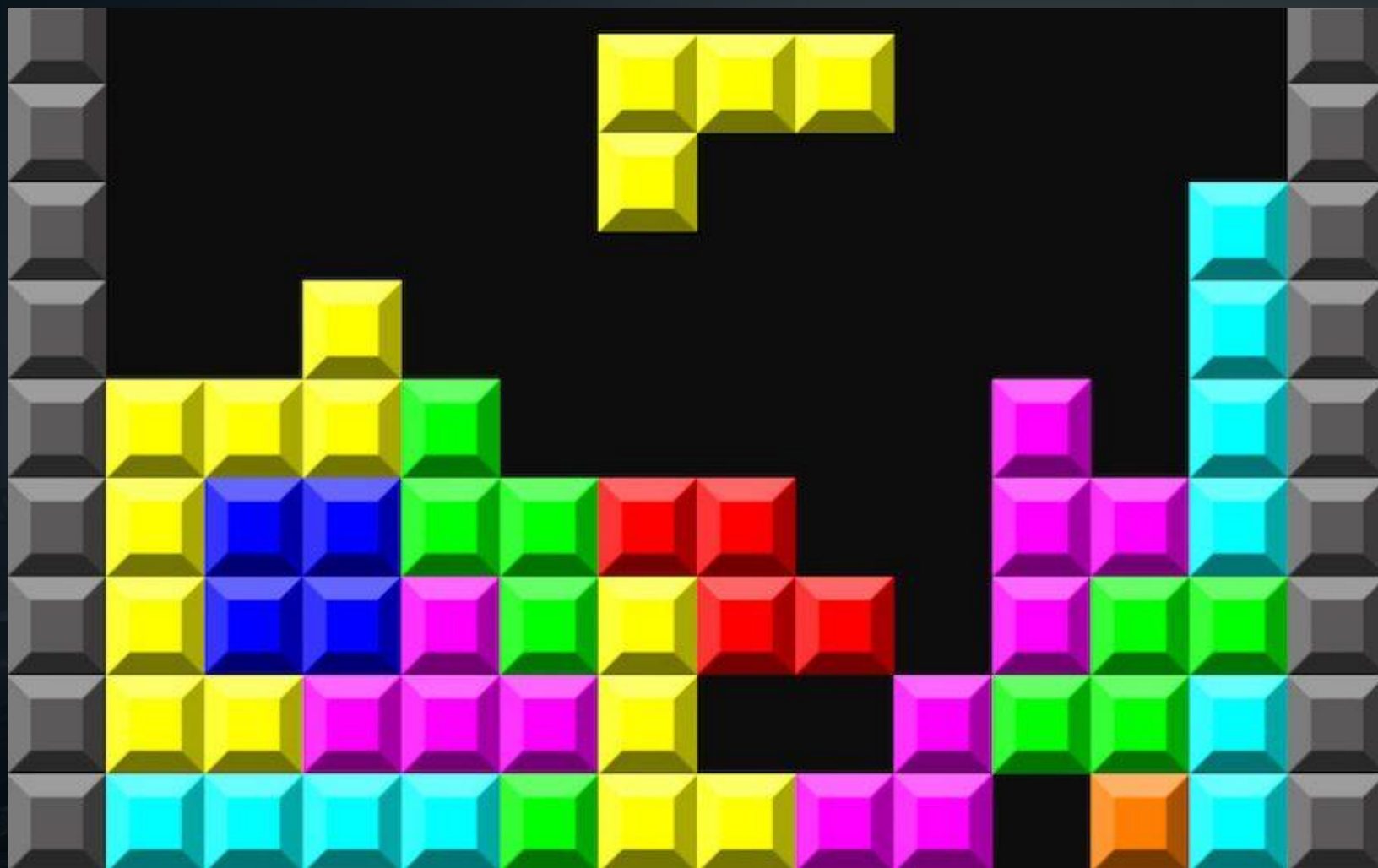
- **Narrative:** what happens as the players plays the game over a longer period
- **Totality of the experience:** gameplay, dialog, notes, setting, graphics etc.
- **In sum:** player's subjective journey through the game
- **Requirements:** five cornerstones of an interactive story

CORE ELEMENTS OF STORYTELLING

1) Focus on Storytelling

- Game MUST be designed to tell a story - from the ground up
- Story MUST be somewhat tangible
- Contain characters, settings, drama





CORE ELEMENTS OF STORYTELLING

- 1) Focus on Storytelling
- **MUST NOT** be a game about puzzles, stacking gems or shooting moving targets
- **Remark:** can contain all of these features...
- ... but they cannot be the core focus of the experience

EXAMPLE: BIOSHOCK



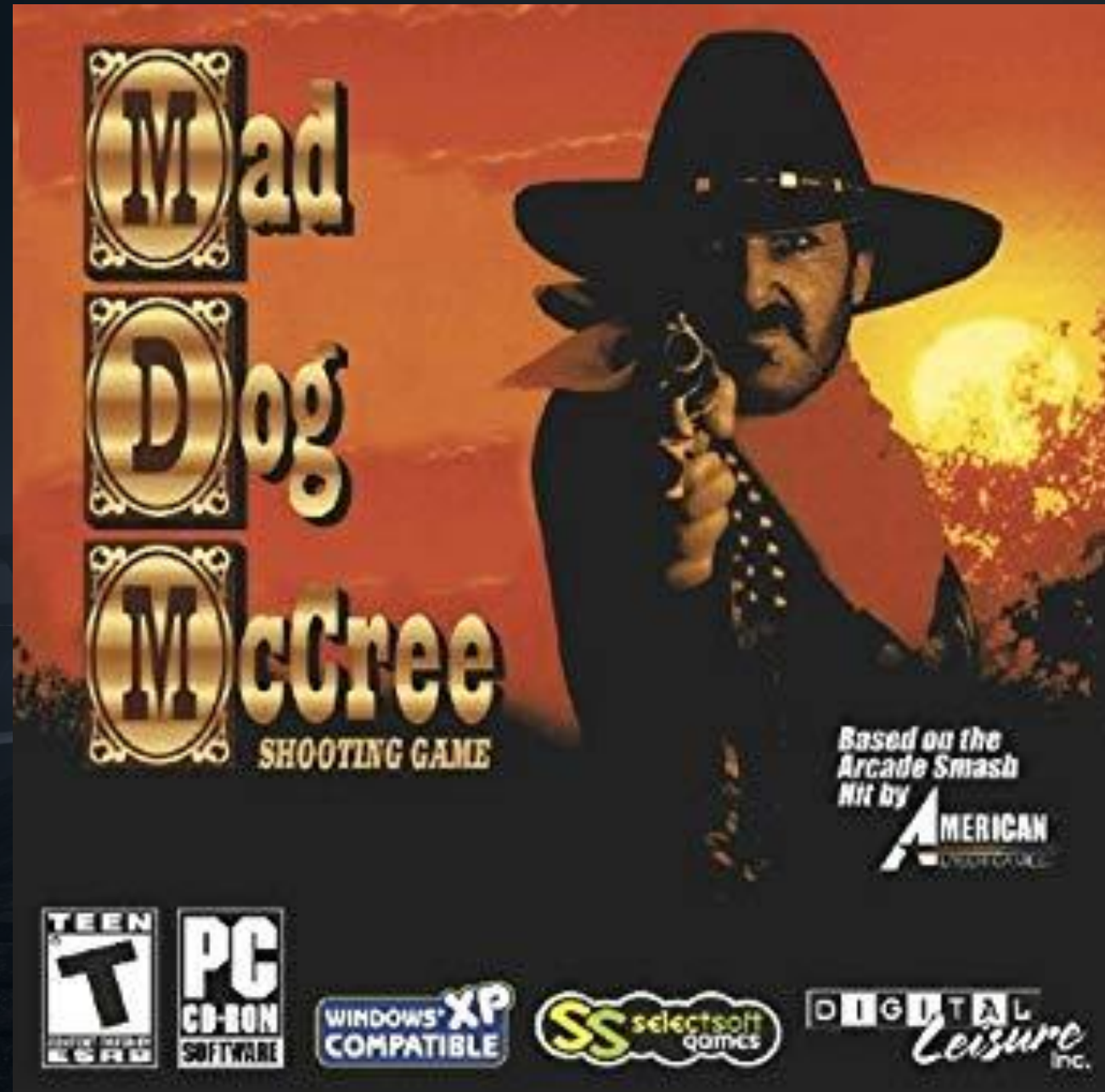
EXAMPLE: BIOSHOCK



CORE ELEMENTS OF STORYTELLING

2) Most of the time is spent playing

- Games = Interactive medium
- Not be about reading or watching cutscenes
- Still room for downtime
- **Main point of interaction in storytelling:** sense of presence





Gaming Experience

Natural Interaction

Immersion

Presence

Flow

Player Types



PRESENCE

- Tele-Presence (Minsky, 1980)
- Psychological state
- Artificiality is not noticed
- „Being there“ (Schultze, 2010)

PRESENCE

- Multifaceted phenomenon (Schultze, 2010)
- Sensory processing
- Affective processing
- Cognitive processing
- 3 components (Tamborini & Bowman, 2010)

SOCIAL PRESENCE

- Simulation of other humans and non-human intelligences (Lee, 2004)
- Artificiality of social actors is not noticed
- Communication as in real life (Behm-Morawitz, 2013)
- Application of social rules in the mediated environment

SPATIAL PRESENCE

- Associated with an immersive experience
- Being physically there
- Being able to act

SELF PRESENCE

- Mediated self = actual self

EMBODIED PRESENCE

- Actions: mediated via avatars
- Representation of the user
- Embodiment of identity

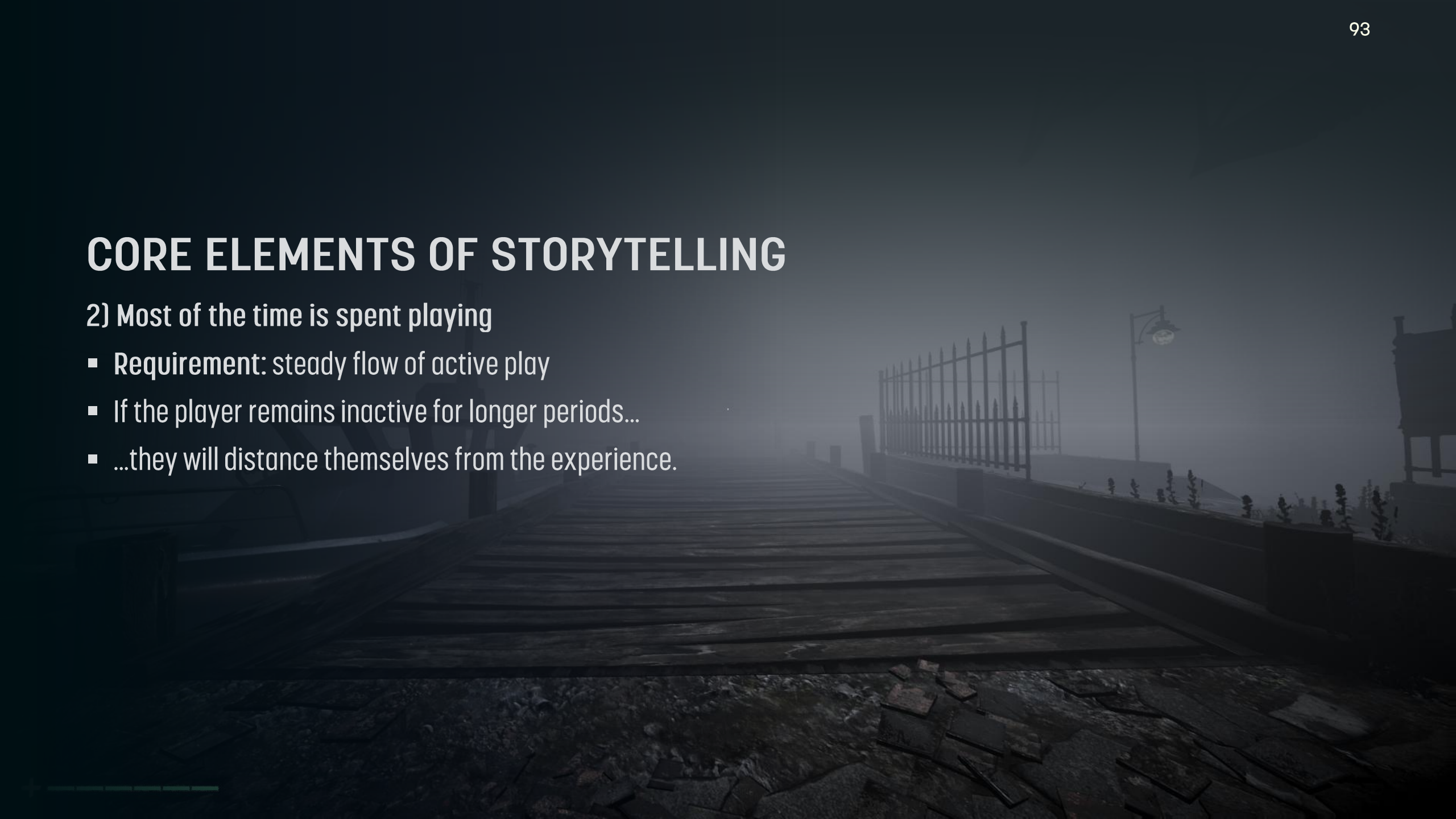
PRESENCE RULES BY THOMAS GRIP

- Constant input
- Agreeable action outcome
- Deterministic mechanics
- Minimal repetition
- Consistency

CORE ELEMENTS OF STORYTELLING

2) Most of the time is spent playing

- Requirement: steady flow of active play
- If the player remains inactive for longer periods...
- ...they will distance themselves from the experience.



CORE ELEMENTS OF STORYTELLING

3) Interactions must make narrative sense

- Actions must be connected to the important happenings
- Two major reasons
- R1: Players must feel as though they are an active part of the story and not just an observer
- "If the gameplay is all about matching gems then it does not matter if players spends 99% of their time interacting; they are not part of any important happenings and their actions are thus irrelevant."

CORE ELEMENTS OF STORYTELLING



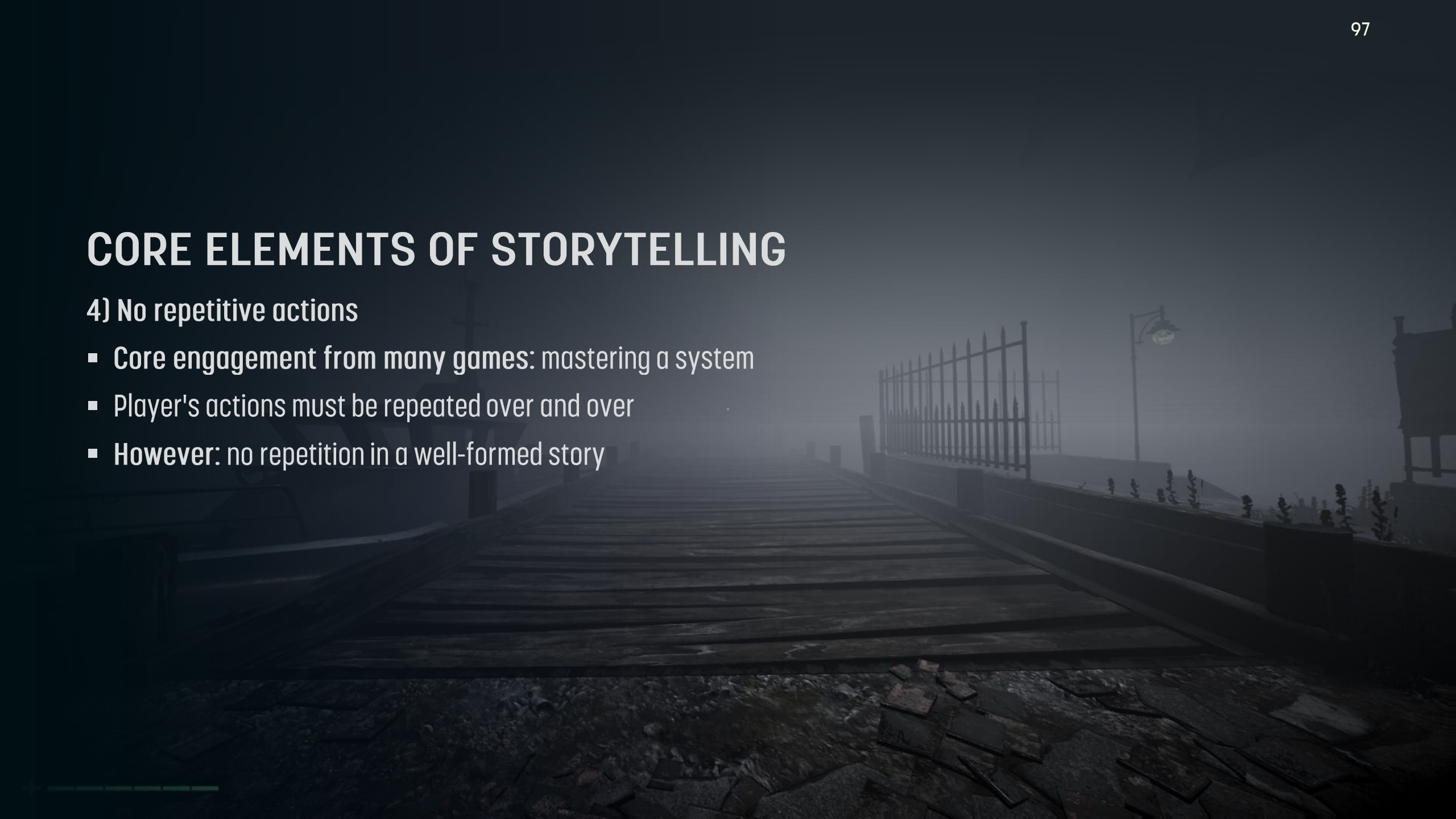
CORE ELEMENTS OF STORYTELLING



CORE ELEMENTS OF STORYTELLING

4) No repetitive actions

- Core engagement from many games: mastering a system
- Player's actions must be repeated over and over
- **However:** no repetition in a well-formed story



CORE ELEMENTS OF STORYTELLING

5) No major progression blocks

- An obstacle never consumes all focus
- Players are playing in order to experience a story
- If they get stuck: focus fade away from the story - new goal: progression
- Three culprits: complex puzzles, mastery-demanding sections and maze-like environments

EXAMPLES

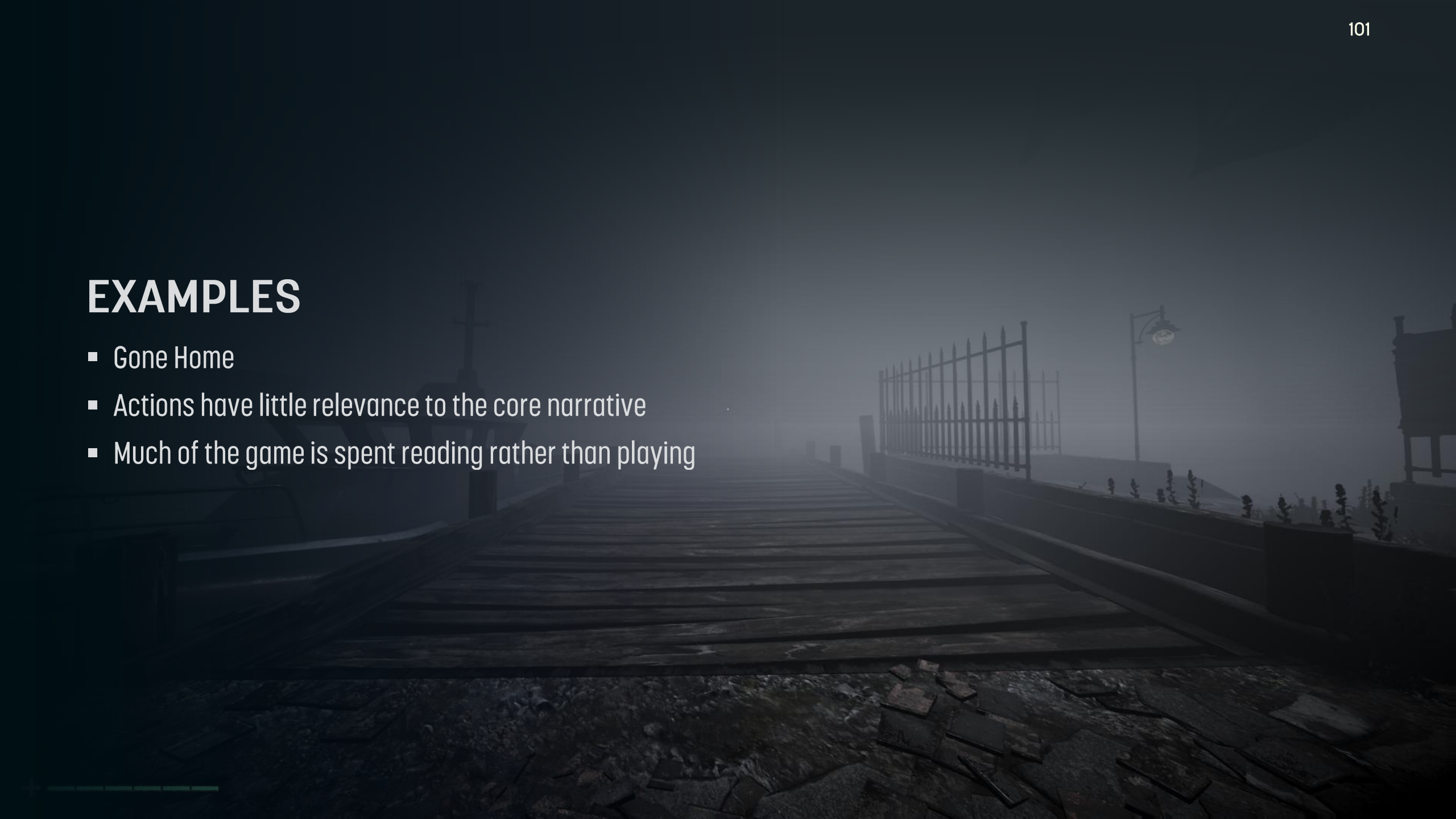
- Action games (Bioshock infinite) all fail on elements 4 and 5 (repetition and progression blocks)
- Element 3 (story related actions) is seldom present
- Often: content is delivered in long cutscenes (element 2)

EXAMPLES

- Heavy Rain & The Walking Dead: feeling like an interactive narrative (fall flat at element 2)
- Are basically just films with interactions
- Interaction not a driving force
- Gameplay is all about reacting - no deliberate planning

EXAMPLES

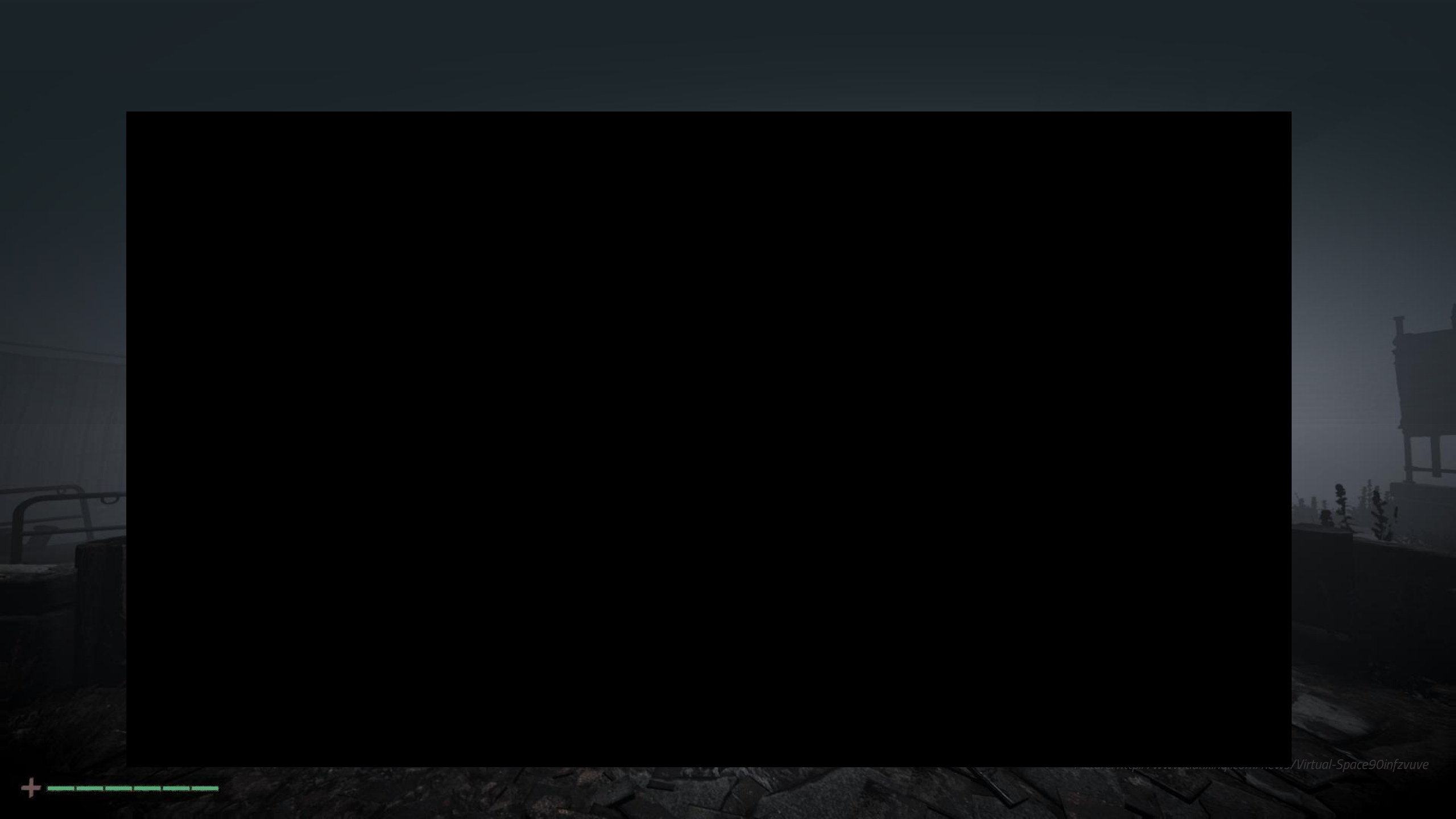
- Gone Home
- Actions have little relevance to the core narrative
- Much of the game is spent reading rather than playing



GOOD EXAMPLES

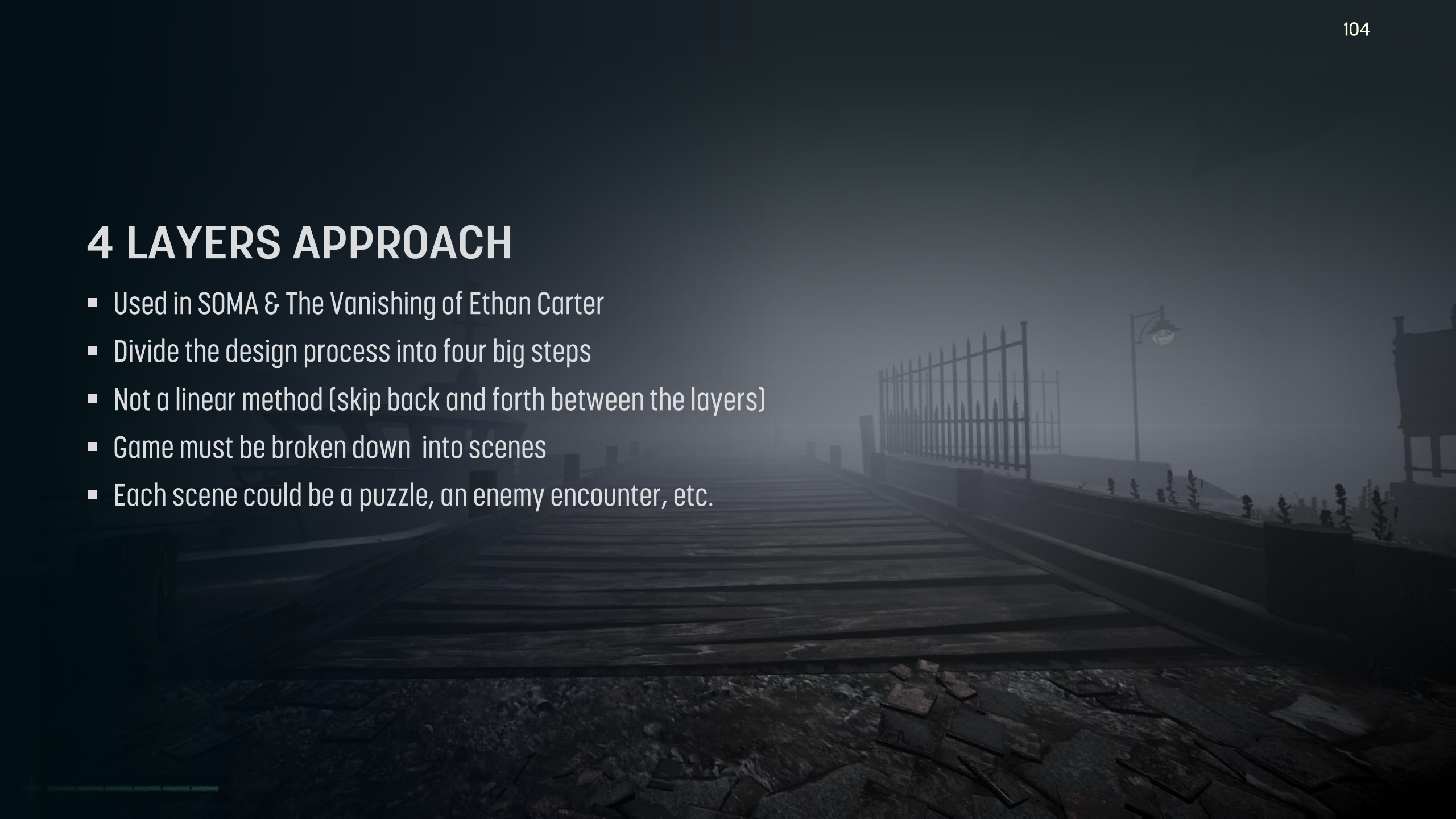
- The Last of Us: Giraffe Scene





4 LAYERS APPROACH

- Used in SOMA & The Vanishing of Ethan Carter
- Divide the design process into four big steps
- Not a linear method (skip back and forth between the layers)
- Game must be broken down into scenes
- Each scene could be a puzzle, an enemy encounter, etc.



LAYERS

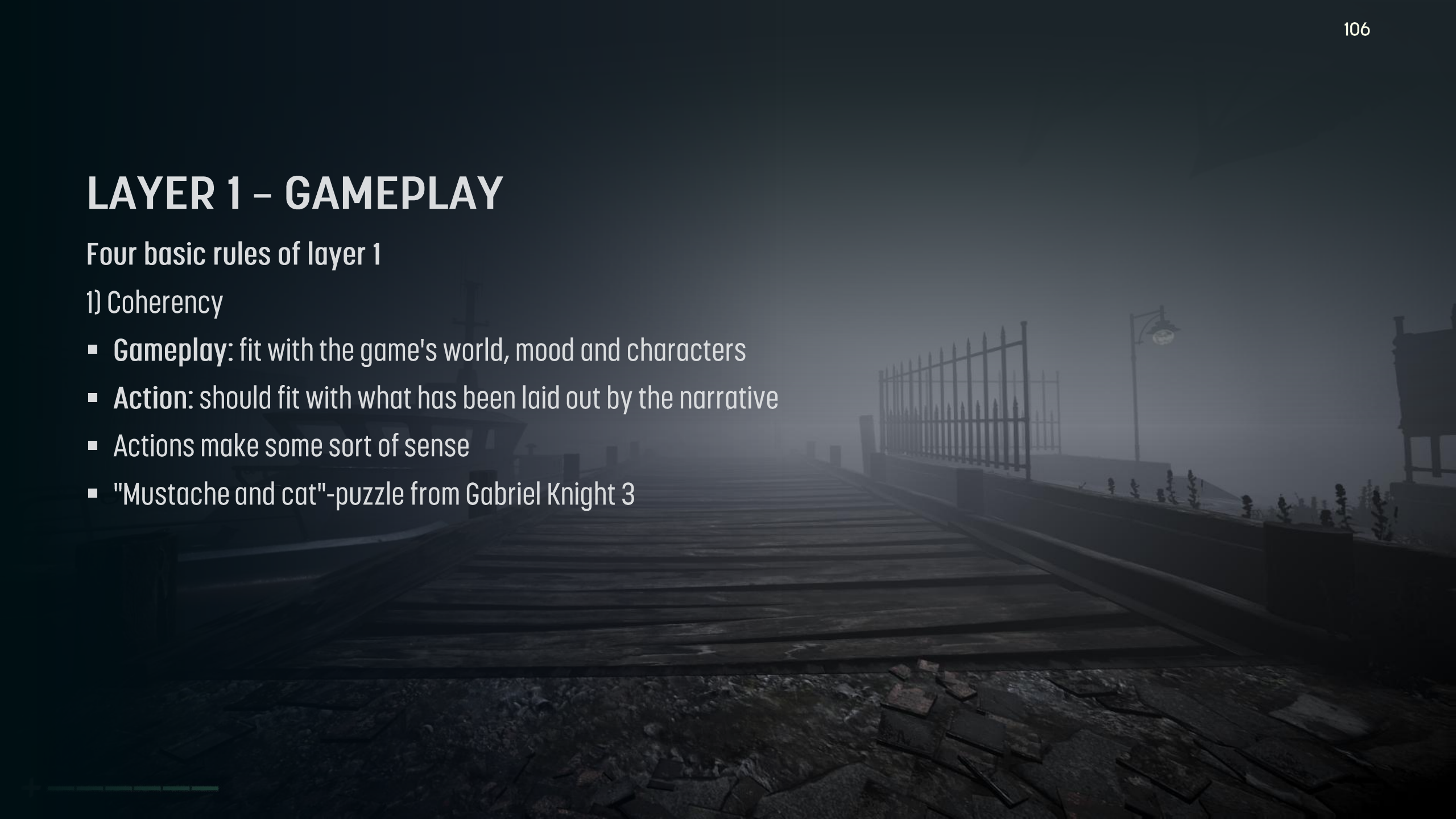
- **Layer 1, Gameplay:** Players must accomplish things through their own mental and manual effort.
- **Layer 2, Narrative Goal:** Players must understand and agree with short-term goals and objectives.
- **Layer 3, Narrative Background:** Players' efforts must unveil more and more of the big picture.
- **Layer 4, Mental Modelling:** The game needs to provide an awareness/experience filter.

LAYER 1 – GAMEPLAY

Four basic rules of layer 1

1) Coherency

- **Gameplay:** fit with the game's world, mood and characters
- **Action:** should fit with what has been laid out by the narrative
- Actions make some sort of sense
- "Mustache and cat"-puzzle from Gabriel Knight 3



LAYER 1 – GAMEPLAY





LAYER 1 – GAMEPLAY

2) Streamlining

- Gameplay: not too convoluted and not too many steps
- Minimize the chance of the player getting stuck
- When the player is stuck for longer periods: focus on the mechanics or tactics
- Classic adventure games: solution to something straightforward requires a massive number of steps to accomplish

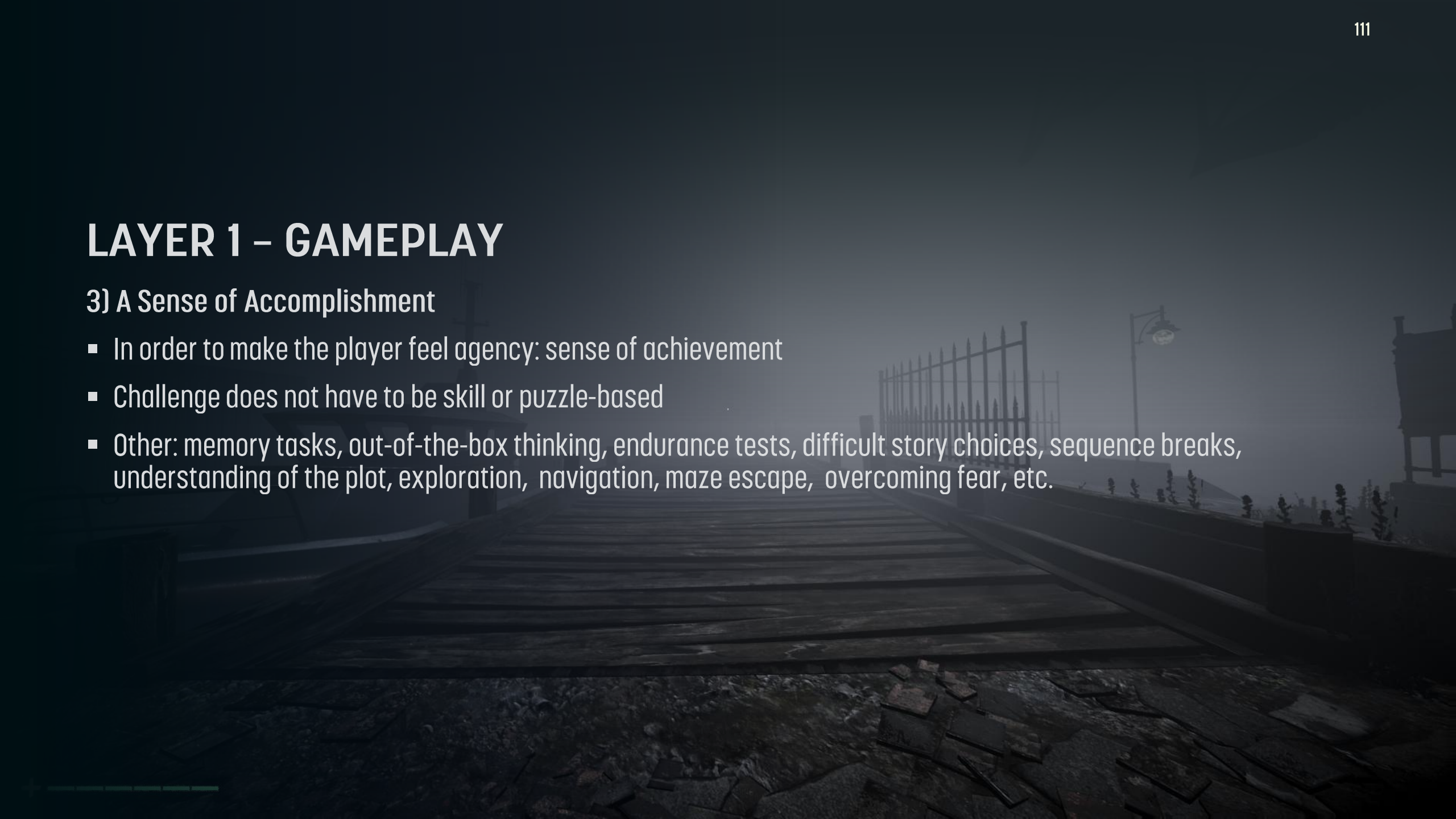
LAYER 1 – GAMEPLAY



LAYER 1 – GAMEPLAY

3) A Sense of Accomplishment

- In order to make the player feel agency: sense of achievement
- Challenge does not have to be skill or puzzle-based
- Other: memory tasks, out-of-the-box thinking, endurance tests, difficult story choices, sequence breaks, understanding of the plot, exploration, navigation, maze escape, overcoming fear, etc.





LAYER 1 – GAMEPLAY

4) Action Confirmation

- Player must understand what it is that they are doing and why they are doing it
- Basic mechanics: "I jumped over the hole to avoid falling down"
- In a scene: not always as straightforward
- Example: player might accidentally activate some machinery without being aware that this was going to happen beforehand...
- ... and afterwards not knowing what it accomplished



Try not to think about it.



We walked.



What do you mean?

LAYER 2 - NARRATIVE GOAL

- Normally: reason to get through gameplay segment is pure progress
- Obstacle: Players try to overcome it because that is what the game demands
- Problematic for the narrative: it removes the experience of being inside a story
- Player stops seeing their actions as part of a story...
- ...and instead sees them as steps towards an abstract gameplay goal
- "Now I just need to get this section out of the way so I can get on with the story"

Don't you have any NEW stories?



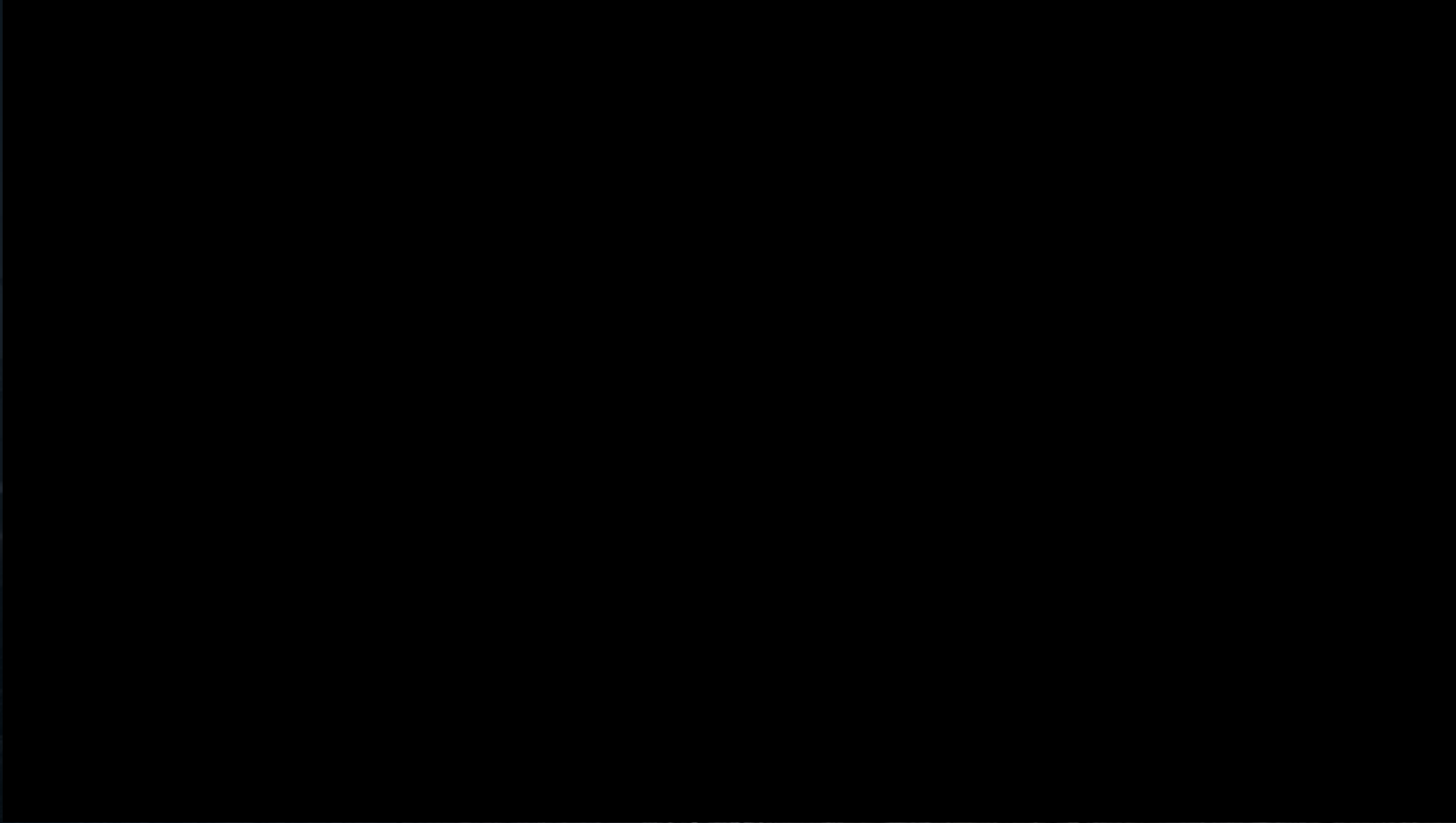
LAYER 2 - NARRATIVE GOAL

Call of Duty: Airport level



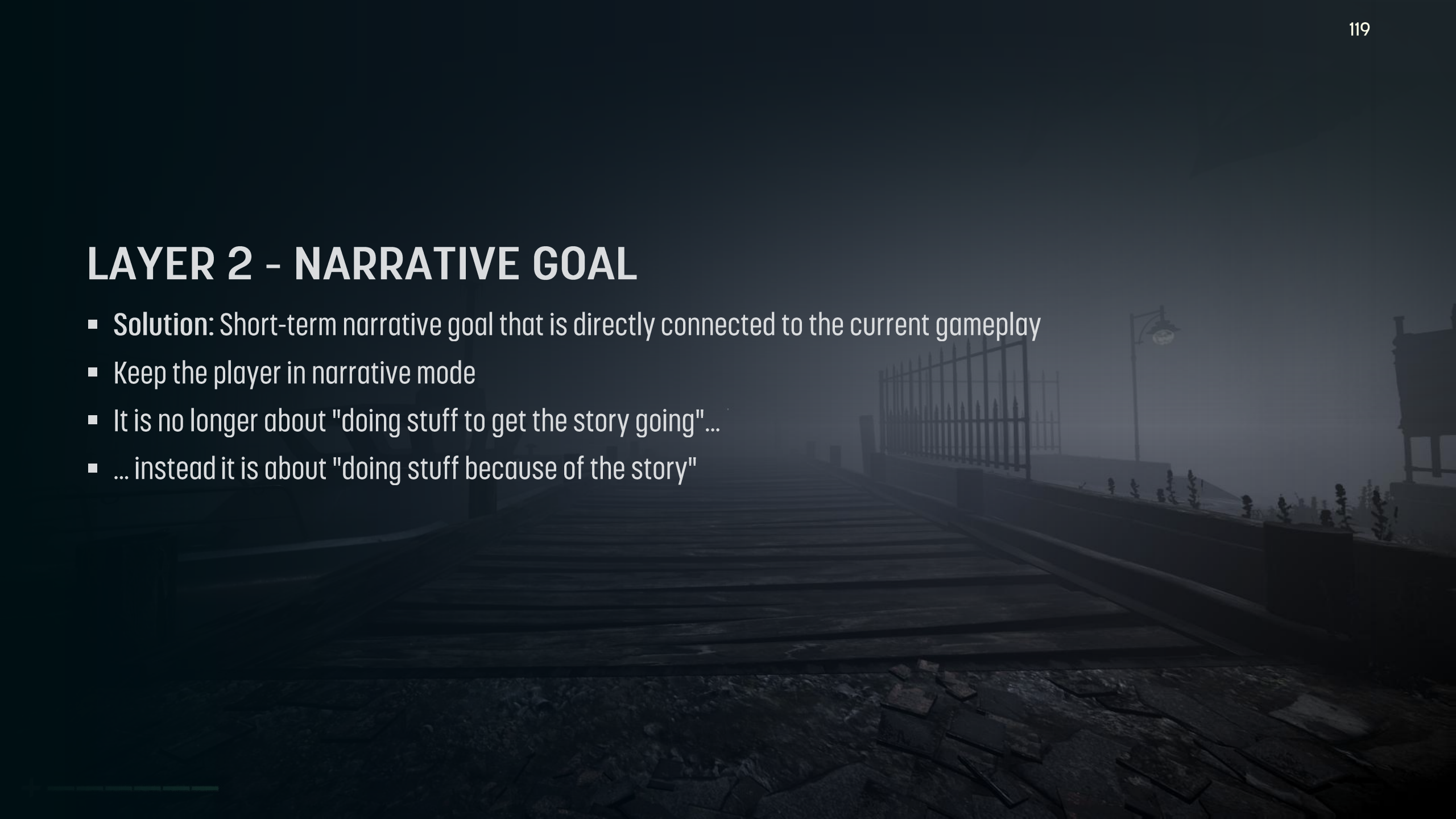
LAYER 2 - NARRATIVE GOAL

Call of Duty: Airport level



LAYER 2 - NARRATIVE GOAL

- **Solution:** Short-term narrative goal that is directly connected to the current gameplay
- Keep the player in narrative mode
- It is no longer about "doing stuff to get the story going"...
- ...instead it is about "doing stuff because of the story"

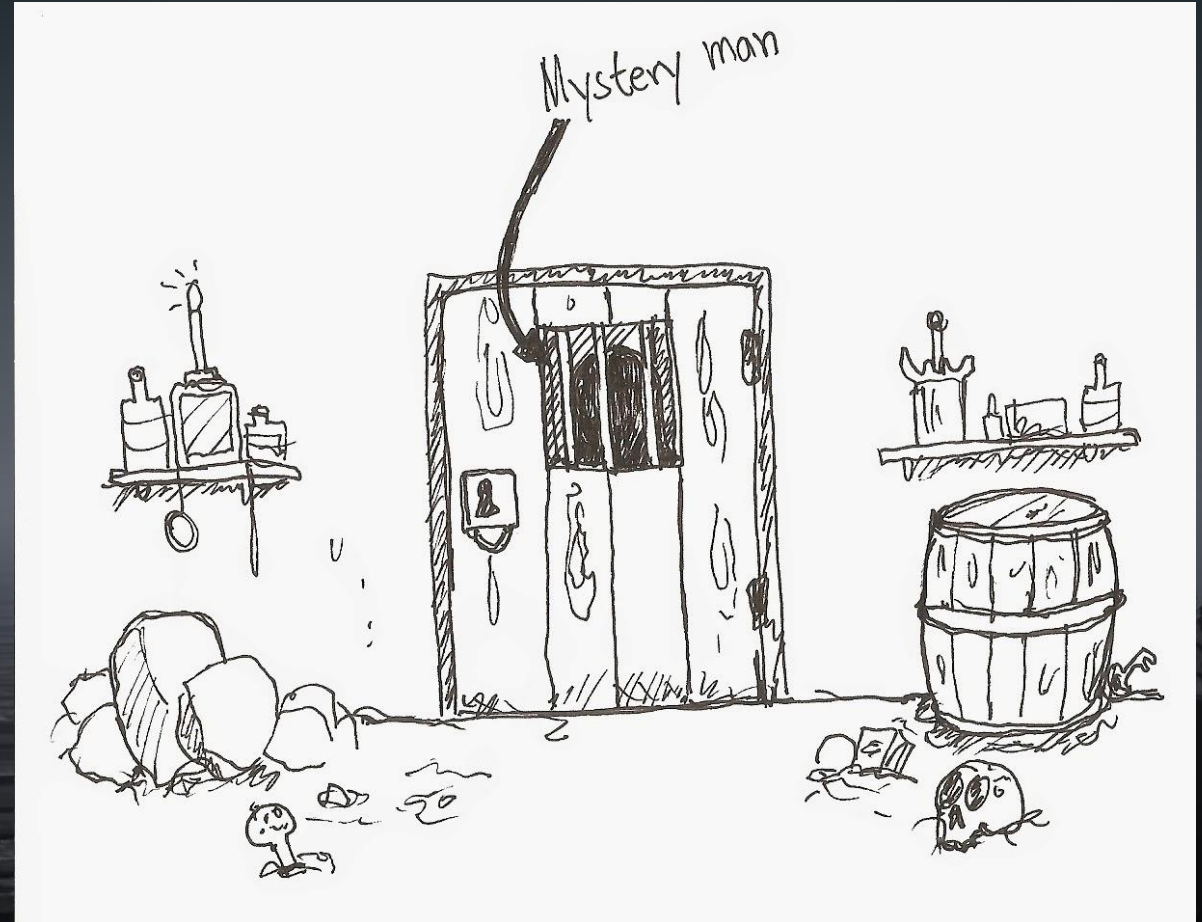


LAYER 2 - NARRATIVE GOAL

- Three different types of narrative goal
- **Mystery:** there is something unknown you want find out about
- **Uncomfortable Environment:** give scene a narrative reason for the player not wanting to stick around - e.g., dark and scary environment, depressing scene, like a funeral reception
- **Character Conflict:** simplistic activities become engaging because of story reasons (e.g., dilemmas in social situations)

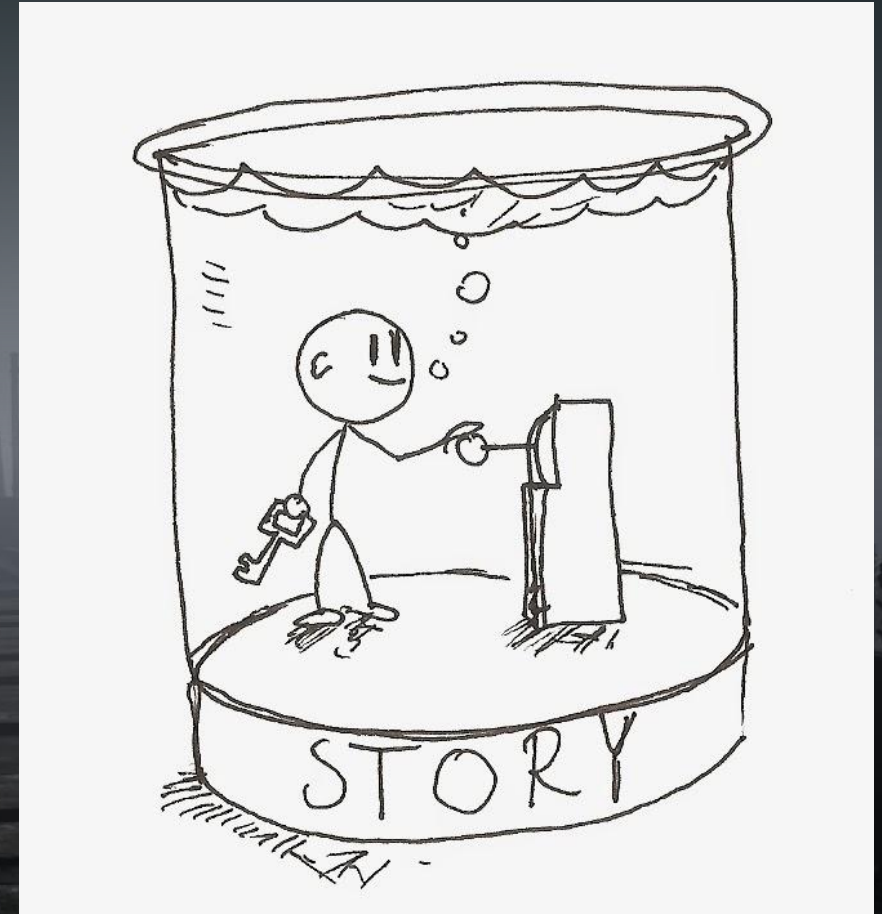
LAYER 2 - NARRATIVE GOAL

- Previous example with mystery
- Man on the other side of the door trying to get in
- retrieve something that's in the room
- "Who is this man?"
- "What object is it that he's after?"



LAYER 3 - NARRATIVE BACKGROUND

- When the player is interacting, it is not just pure gameplay...
- ..., they are constantly being fed story at the same time
- "doing stuff in order to make the story appear"
- player's actions are no longer just a means to an end...
- ... they are what causes the story to emerge as you play



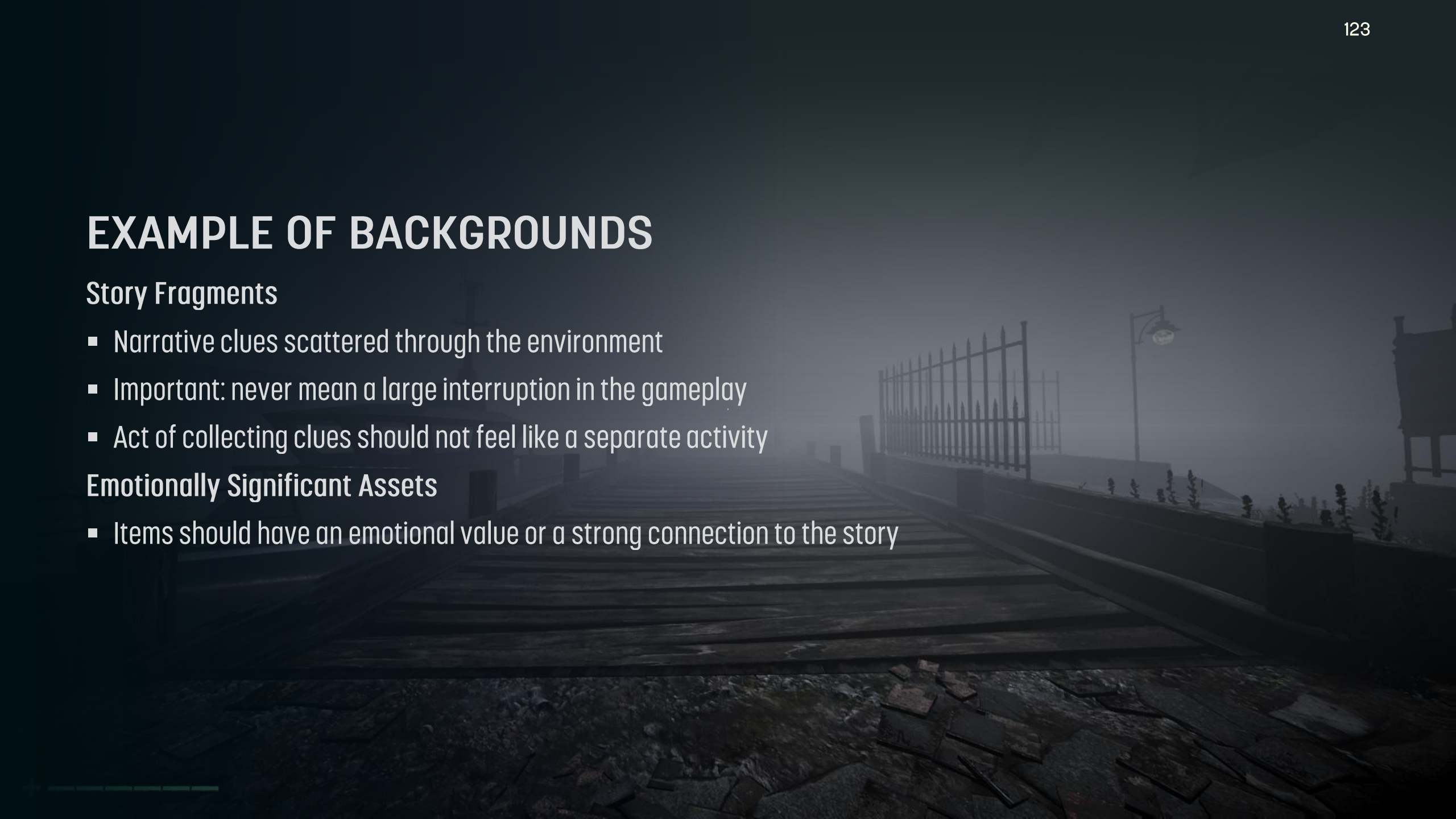
EXAMPLE OF BACKGROUNDS

Story Fragments

- Narrative clues scattered through the environment
- Important: never mean a large interruption in the gameplay
- Act of collecting clues should not feel like a separate activity

Emotionally Significant Assets

- Items should have an emotional value or a strong connection to the story





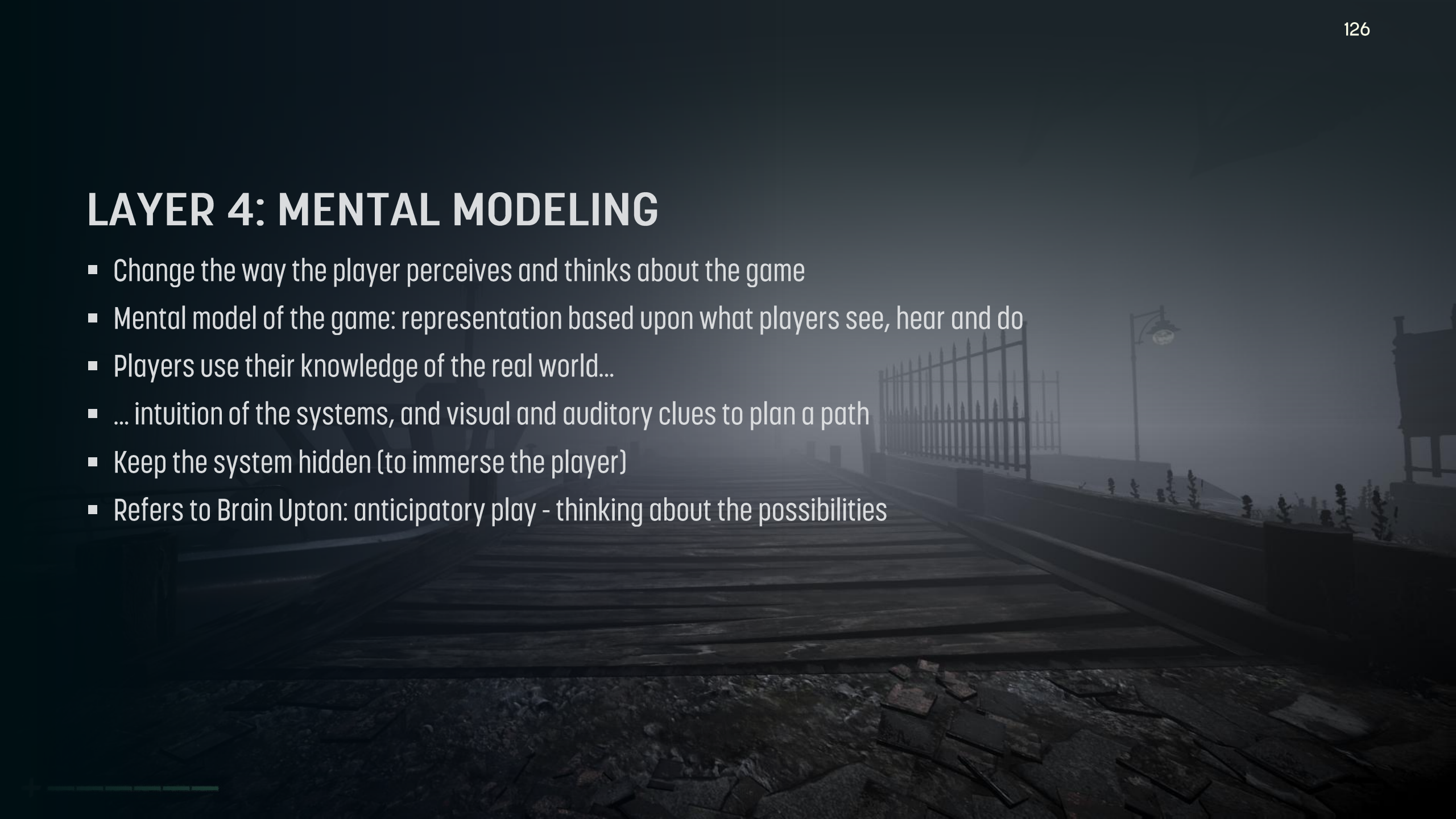
EXAMPLE OF BACKGROUNDS

1. Story fragments in the form of clues (pictures, texts, etc.)
2. Hints: the man behind the door
3. Man comment on the player's actions and give hints
4. Man who hid the key for reasons



LAYER 4: MENTAL MODELING

- Change the way the player perceives and thinks about the game
- Mental model of the game: representation based upon what players see, hear and do
- Players use their knowledge of the real world...
- ... intuition of the systems, and visual and auditory clues to plan a path
- Keep the system hidden (to immerse the player)
- Refers to Brain Upton: anticipatory play - thinking about the possibilities



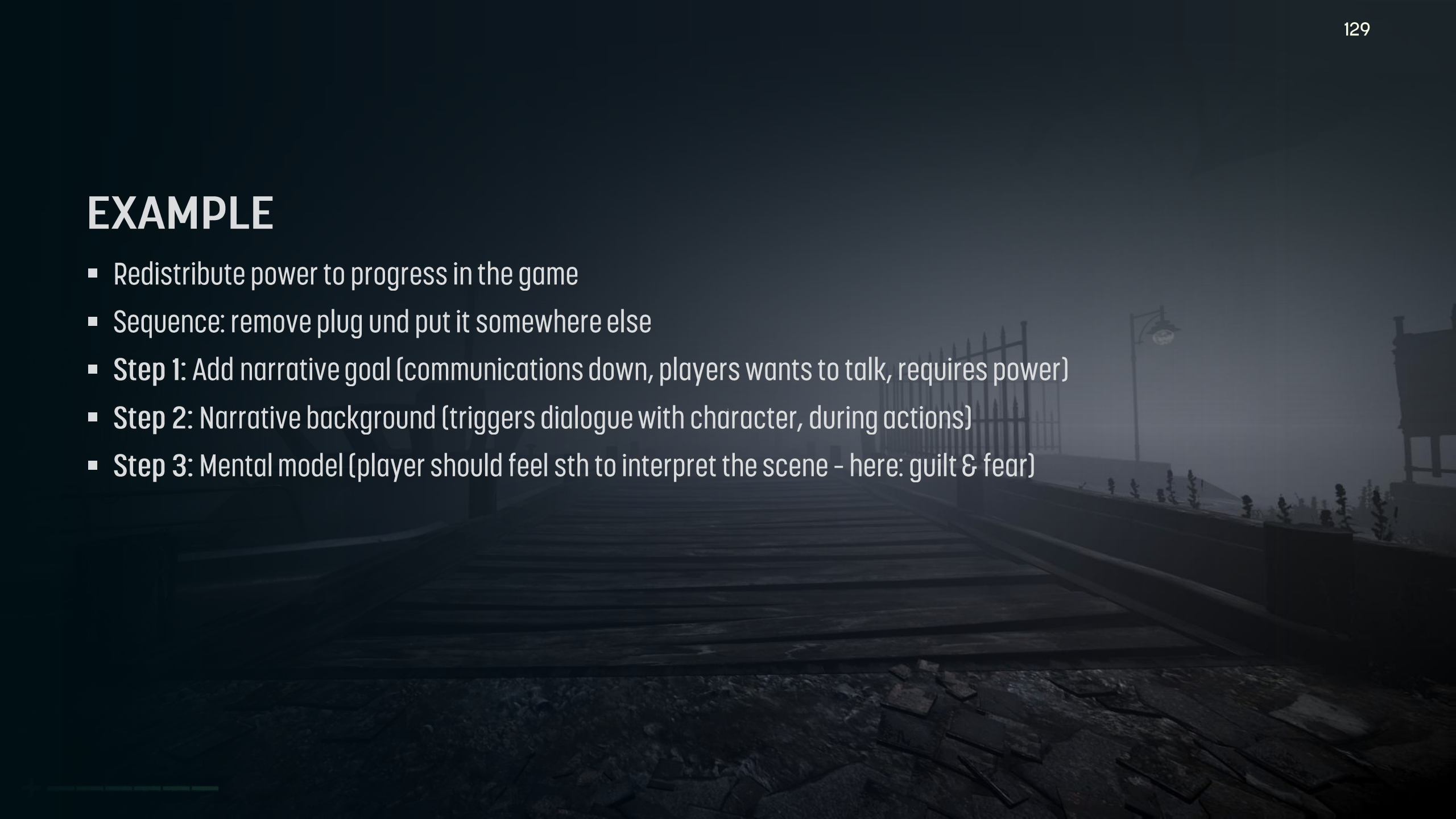
4 LAYERS APPROACH: EXAMPLE





EXAMPLE

- Redistribute power to progress in the game
- Sequence: remove plug und put it somewhere else
- Step 1: Add narrative goal (communications down, players wants to talk, requires power)
- Step 2: Narrative background (triggers dialogue with character, during actions)
- Step 3: Mental model (player should feel sth to interpret the scene - here: guilt & fear)



GAMES WITH A GOOD STORY?



THANK YOU FOR YOUR ATTENTION!

